

What Does the Bible Say About Transgender Identity?

*Gender, the Body, and the Church's Christ-Centered
Response*

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INTRODUCTION

THE QUESTION NOBODY PREPARED THE CHURCH TO ANSWER

*Why the church keeps failing transgender people
— and how clarity and compassion can occupy
the same room*

GENDER IDENTITY, THE BIBLE, AND WHAT WE OWE PEOPLE MADE IN GOD'S IMAGE

The email arrived on a Tuesday. A pastor I know, writing about his twenty-three-year-old son, who is gay, living with another man, and now identifying as a woman. The pastor had no theology for any of this. Neither did his church. What he had instead was panic, denial, a few Bible verses deployed like grenades — and a son who had stopped calling.

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for the most confused person. We have
not been.*

They can. The church just has not done the work.

THE TWO FAILURES: DISMISSAL AND CAPITULATION

What happened instead is predictable. Some churches went full dismissal — mockery disguised as conviction, using people's deepest confusion as punchlines, refusing to learn names, weaponizing Scripture, making the gospel look like an ideology that serves the already-certain at the expense of the searching. These churches lost any credibility with the person actually struggling. Other churches went full capitulation — affirming everything, asking no questions, treating doubt about gender ideology as bigotry, making the gospel sound like "whatever you think about yourself is true," refusing to do theology because theology might create discomfort. These churches

Both failures produce the same result: the person at the center of the question — the teenager confused about their body, the young adult in genuine distress, the parent torn between love and conviction — has nowhere to turn that feels safe. The church should be the safest place for the most confused person. We have not been.

WHAT THE CHURCH OWES THE CONFUSED PERSON

This book exists because the church needs to do what it has refused to do: the theological work. Not the political work. Not the culture-war work. The theology — the hard, careful, sometimes uncomfortable work of asking what Scripture actually teaches about the body, about gender, about identity, about the image of God, and holding that alongside genuine pastoral concern for people in real pain.

This is not a book about whether transgender identity is a sin. The Bible does not speak directly to gender identity as we frame it now; it speaks to other things — the body, sexual difference, the created order, what it means to be made in God's image — and we have to do the theological work of thinking carefully about how those truths apply to people living in a complicated world. This is a book about theological honesty and pastoral compassion occupying the same space, about what we owe people made in God's image, about what the church looks like when it refuses to reduce anyone to a debate.

Some people will read this and say I am too harsh on cultural positions they hold dear. Others will say I am not harsh enough. Both will be right. The book lives in the tension where most real pastoral work lives — between

We have not believed this about gender. We have chosen sides, we have weaponized Scripture, and we have made the question into a culture war rather than an opportunity to show what Christian love looks like when it refuses to go soft on either end. This book rejects both failures. It does the theology. It holds the tension. It insists that biblical conviction and genuine love for confused people are not in competition — they are the same call.

Read it asking one question: What does the church owe the person standing in front of us who is genuinely confused about their body and their identity? The answer will cost us something. Costly hope always does.

WHY THIS CONVERSATION MATTERS FOR THE CHURCH NOW

The statistics are real. The pain is real. The confusion is real. The suicide rates among transgender youth are real, and so is the fact that many of those young people were raised in churches that mocked them or abandoned them. The tragedy of young people on irreversible medical paths without sufficient psychological evaluation is real. All of it is real, and the church has a responsibility to name what is happening, understand what is happening, and respond with both clarity and care.

But here is what else is real: a young person's distress

Each chapter stands alone, so you can read them in order or jump to what you need most; but the argument builds across all of them, and reading straight through will serve you better. You will find exegetical work — I take Scripture seriously and will show you the work. You will find historical and theological grounding: the eunuch theology, the body theology, the image-of-God theology. You will find honest acknowledgment of where the Bible is less specific than we might want, and pastoral counsel for the situations you actually face — the child in your church, the family at your small group, the employee you supervise, the parent you love.

You will not find easy answers. You will not find a simple checklist of what the church should do. What you will find is permission to think carefully, to hold convictions without cruelty, to love people without abandoning truth, and to do the work that most of American Christianity has refused to do. The work is serious. The stakes are souls. The gospel is big enough for this, but you have to believe that before you can live it — and this book will help you believe it.

What does it look like when the church fails a family in real time? Not in the abstract — in the actual living room where a mother discovers that her eleven-year-old daughter has started identifying as a boy. Her name is Rachel. She was at FBC last Sunday, sitting in the pew like she always does, blonde hair in a ponytail, Girl Scout uniform from Wednesday night, normal — or what normal looks like from the back of a church where we see faces but not lives.

The week before, her daughter came home from school and said, "I think I'm a boy." Rachel panicked. She did not know what this meant. Was this a phase? Was her daughter experiencing trauma? Was she being influenced by peers? Was this dysphoria? Was this depression? Rachel knew the answers to none of these questions. She called her pastor, who said, "Bring her in and we'll pray about it." That was the church's wisdom — no psychology, no theology about the body, no structure for thinking, just prayer, as if prayer could substitute for understanding.

Rachel went to her small group. One woman said, "You need to affirm her identity immediately or she will kill herself." Another woman said, "Do not affirm this. It is sin. Your daughter needs to repent." Both women were trying to help. Both created more panic. Rachel is still at church, but she is not at FBC anymore; she found another church she believed would help her think. She is not affirming everything and she is not rejecting everything — she is trying to love her daughter while also believing some things about the body and biology.

The tragedy is that FBC could have been that place. The

The church needs to be different. Not different in doctrine. Different in approach. The church needs to be a place where parents can say: "I do not know what this means. I do not understand what my child is experiencing. I love my child and I also have convictions about the body. Help me think through this. Do not tell me to affirm everything. Do not tell me to reject everything. Help me."

That is what this introduction is about — not settling the gender question, but creating space for families to actually handle it with the church's help instead of the church's condemnation or the church's absence. The church has been absent, and that silence has cost real people real relationships and real safety.

CHAPTER 1

MALE AND FEMALE HE CREATED THEM

*What Genesis 1:27 actually teaches about gender,
the image of God, and the limits of a single verse*

The verse sits in every Bible the way a stone sits in a riverbed, so familiar that people step over it without looking. Genesis 1:27.

*So God created mankind in his own image, in the
image of God he created them; male and female he
created them.*

— GENESIS 1:27

For some, the verse settles the question immediately. Men are men. Women are women. Created that way, by God, end of discussion. For others, the verse settles nothing. How can it? It does not address the person who experiences their sex assigned at birth as fundamentally misaligned with their sense of self; it does not address intersex conditions; it does not address the feeling of dysphoria. To use Genesis 1:27 as a dismissal of someone's lived experience is to pretend the verse is more

Genesis 1:27 is not a conversation- ender. It is a place to begin.

The truth is in the middle, or rather, above both positions. Genesis 1:27 teaches us something deep about gender. Not everything. Something deep. And if we read it with the care it deserves, we will find we have been thinking about gender at the wrong level all along.

THE TEXT AND ITS CONTEXT: ZAKAR AND NEQEVAH

Let's start with what the verse actually says.

*So God created mankind in his own image, in the
image of God he created them; male and female he
created them.*

— GENESIS 1:27

The Hebrew word for "mankind" here is Adam, the generic term for humanity. The verse is not describing the first man; it is describing humanity as God created it, and it says God created humanity in two forms: male and female. The word for male is zakar, and the word for female is neqevah. These are biological designations. The text is not metaphorical here. When God creates the human, God creates it in sexual difference, and one of the most fundamental facts about human existence, according to Genesis, is that we come in two kinds.

What is the image of God? Not the body. Not genitalia. The image of God is something else entirely; it is representation, it is relationship, it is rule. When Genesis says humans are made in the image of God, it means humans represent God, reflect His character, and stand as His representatives in creation, both male and female. The image of God is not gendered. Both male and female image God, both carry the divine stamp, and both are responsible for how they live. This is subversive. In ancient Near Eastern contexts, it was not obvious that both male and female would bear the divine image equally, yet the text insists on it.

But here is what the text also insists on: sexual difference matters. God could have created humanity as genderless beings, could have created one unified human form; instead, God created humanity in sexual difference, and God called it good. This raises an immediate question. If the image of God is genderless, why does God create gender at all?

THE GIFT OF SEXUAL DIFFERENCE

The answer is in the rest of Genesis. In Genesis 1:27, God creates humanity male and female; in Genesis 1:28, God gives them a command: "Be fruitful and increase in number; fill the earth and subdue it." Sexual difference is

Sexual difference, in the biblical account, is not a curse and not a necessary evil. It is a gift, the way God structured human life so that we would need each other, depend on each other, and participate together in the ongoing work of creation. This is important, because the Bible does not treat sexual difference as incidental to human identity; it treats it as fundamental. You do not just happen to be male or female. Your sexual difference shapes how you move through the world, how you relate to others, and how you participate in God's plan.

And this is crucial: being male or female is not the same as what it means to be made in God's image. The image of God is what you share with every other human; sexual difference is how you, as an image-bearer, live out that calling in a particular way. This is the distinction we have lost. We have made gender into an identity marker that obscures the more fundamental fact: you are made in God's image, and everything else, male, female, the ways you express those realities, flows from that.

WHAT GENESIS 1:27 DOES NOT SAY

This is where we need to be honest. Genesis 1:27 does not say what happens when someone's biological sex and their internal sense of gender do not align. The verse acknowledges that sexual difference exists; it does not describe every possible variation of human experience, does not address intersex conditions, does not speak to

This is actually how theology works. You start with what Scripture says clearly, and then you think carefully about how those truths apply to situations Scripture does not directly address; you do not pretend the Bible says more than it does, you do not ignore what it does say, you think. Genesis 1:27 says sexual difference is real, created by God, and called good. It also says both male and female image God equally. Those truths are not small, but they are not exhaustive, and they do not, by themselves, tell us how to love someone whose experience of gender is complicated, confused, or painful.

To use Genesis 1:27 as a conversation-ender is to avoid the real work. The real work is asking: if sexual difference is good and created by God, what does that mean for someone whose relationship to their sexual body is not good? If both male and female image God equally, does that settle what gender means? If the image of God is not gendered but bodies are, how do those two truths coexist? These are the questions the church has failed to ask.

THE IMAGE OF GOD BEYOND GENDER

Let's push deeper into what "image of God" actually means, because this is where Genesis 1:27 becomes useful for the harder conversations. When the Bible says humans are made in the image of God, it is not talking about physical appearance; God does not have a body until the

Both male and female bear this image. A woman is not made in the image of God because she is female; she is made in the image of God because she is human, and her femaleness is a particular expression of her humanity, not the foundation of her image-bearing. This matters because it means the image of God is deeper than gender, and it means gender, while real and good, is not the ultimate category of human identity. You are made in God's image. That is the ultimate fact about you, and everything else, male, female, your particular personality, your talents, your weaknesses, your confusion, everything else is downstream from that.

If you lose that, you get lost. You start believing that your identity is at its core about your gender, your sexuality, your body as experienced, and you forget the more basic truth: you are a representative of God on earth. That is your calling. That is your identity. This is not to say gender does not matter. It is to say gender is not what in the end matters.

THE BODY IS GOOD, BUT THE BODY IS NOT GOD

Here is where Genesis 1:27 intersects with a larger biblical claim: the body is good. God does not create the body and then regret it; God does not create sexual

When someone says "I know my body is female, but I am male," they are making a claim that something internal to their identity supersedes something external to their body. The church has largely refused to engage with this claim carefully. Either the church says "Your body is the final word, accept it," or the church says "Your identity as you experience it is the final word, your body is incidental." Both responses miss what Genesis 1:27 actually teaches. Your body is good, your experience of your body matters, but your identity goes deeper than your body. Your identity is rooted in the image of God.

That distinction opens a different kind of pastoral conversation. Not "Your body is wrong" and not "Your body is irrelevant," but "Your body is real and good, and it is also not the ultimate word on who you are. You are made in God's image. That image is not dependent on feeling comfortable in your body, and your confusion about your body does not erase that you image God."

This is costly hope. It does not promise that your dysphoria will disappear if you accept your biological sex, and it does not promise that your distress will vanish. It promises something harder: that you matter more than your suffering, that you image God beyond your gender experience, and that the church has a responsibility to help you think about your body and identity from a place

THE PATTERN AND THE EXCEPTION

This is where we need to be careful about how we apply Genesis 1:27. The verse describes a pattern: God creates humanity male and female, God creates sexual difference, and sexual difference is part of God's good order. Patterns are real, and they matter. When you see a pattern throughout Scripture, throughout nature, throughout human experience, male and female, designed to complement each other, designed to reproduce, designed as the fundamental structure of how humans live together, that pattern tells us something true about how God made the world.

But patterns have exceptions, all of them. The pattern of day and night is real; the sun rises and sets. But on the poles, the sun does not rise for months. That does not make the pattern false; it makes the exception real. In the same way, the pattern of sexual difference, male and female, is real. Scripture emphasizes it, biology emphasizes it, the structure of reproduction emphasizes it. But exceptions exist. Intersex conditions exist. People experience their gender in ways that do not fit the pattern.

Does the existence of exceptions invalidate the pattern? No. Does the pattern invalidate the exceptions? No. This is where Genesis 1:27 becomes useful for the actual work of theology. The verse tells us the pattern is real and good; it does not tell us there are no exceptions, and it does not tell us what to do when someone experiences deep dysphoria about the body they have. Those are questions you have to think through with the rest of Scripture, with pastoral care, with theological precision, and with genuine love for the

IS "MALE AND FEMALE" A MERISM?

Genesis 1:27 uses a rhetorical device that has almost completely disappeared from how we read it. The device is called a merism. A merism is when two opposite extremes are used to describe everything between them; it is not a list of two things, but a way of saying "everything in the spectrum between these two points." When the psalmist says, "From the rising of the sun to its setting, the name of the Lord is praised," the writer is not talking about two locations. The writer is using a merism to describe every location on earth. From sunrise to sunset covers the whole world.

Genesis 1:27 does something similar. "Male and female he created them." This is not a list of exactly two genders; it is a way of describing the full spectrum of human sexual difference, from the strongest expressions of maleness to the strongest expressions of femaleness to everything in between, God created all of it. This changes something important. If Genesis 1:27 is using a merism, then it is not claiming there are only two genders. It is claiming that sexual difference exists on a spectrum, and God created all of it. The text acknowledges that variation exists; it does not try to reduce variation to simplicity.

This is actually what the science shows. Sexual difference is not a binary switch where everyone is either entirely male or entirely female; it involves chromosomes, hormones, anatomy, and neurology, and all of these can vary. A person can be XX chromosomally but have higher testosterone exposure in utero. A person can be XY chromosomally but be insensitive to testosterone. A

This does not mean that sexual difference is purely a social construct. It means that while the pattern of male and female is real, the pattern has gradations; the pattern is not an on-off switch, it is a spectrum. This matters because it means the church can affirm the reality of sexual difference, male and female as the main pattern, while also acknowledging that some people exist in the variations and gradations. The church has largely failed to make this distinction, treating Genesis 1:27 as proof that everyone fits neatly into either male or female and not acknowledging that sexual difference itself is more complex than that.

Some theologians argue that because Genesis uses a merism, the inclusion of variations is actually biblical, and this is worth taking seriously. The text does not say "only male and female." It says "male and female," using the rhetorical device that indicates "from the clearest male expression to the clearest female expression and everything between." This does not resolve the transgender question, but it does complicate it in a helpful way. It says: sexual difference exists, it is created by God, and it is more complex than we typically acknowledge.

THE FALL, THE IMAGE, AND WHY THE MERISM MATTERS

Genesis 1:27 uses a merism, male and female covering the full spectrum of sexual difference as God created it. But what happens after the fall? Does the fall change what

This is not unreasonable theology. The fall does corrupt everything. It corrupts our sexuality, our bodies, our sense of self; the body is subject to decay, the desires that arise from the body are sometimes twisted, and the alignment between what we are and what we feel is sometimes fractured. This is all true. But it takes an important step that needs examination: it treats dysphoria as categorically the same as other post-fall sexual disorders, grouping lustful thoughts, twisted desires, infidelity, and sexual exploitation together with dysphoria as a manifestation of sin's corruption. The person experiencing dysphoria is implicitly asked to see their dysphoria as evidence of their own sinful fallen nature.

But is this right? Consider the actual phenomenology of dysphoria. A person experiences dysphoria; they do not choose it, they do not actively desire it, they wake up in a body that feels fundamentally misaligned with who they are. This is suffering, not sin. This is a consequence of

This is where the distinction between sin and suffering becomes crucial. Not everything that is wrong is sin. Some things are wrong because creation is fallen. A person born with severe mental illness did not sin to create that illness; a person born with a disability did not sin to create that disability; a person experiencing dysphoria did not sin to create that dysphoria. These are consequences of living in a fallen creation, not evidence of personal sin.

Here is where the merism of Genesis 1:27 becomes pastoral. If Genesis 1:27 describes a spectrum from the clearest maleness to the clearest femaleness and everything between, then sexual difference includes natural variations, and these variations are not new, not modern inventions; they are built into how human sexual development actually works. Some people are born with variations in chromosomes, some in hormone levels, some in hormone receptivity, some in the development of sexual characteristics, some in the neurology that shapes their sense of self. These are not sins. They are part of how sexual difference actually expresses itself in a fallen creation.

The intersex person is not experiencing dysphoria caused by sin; the intersex person is experiencing the reality of biological variation in a fallen world. They did not choose this, they cannot be blamed for it, and the merism of Genesis 1:27, male and female, includes them. They are part of the spectrum.

Dysphoria itself is more complex. Some dysphoria may

But some dysphoria may be rooted in genuine sexual variation that is not obvious on the surface. A person might be chromosomally one sex but have experienced atypical hormone exposure in utero; the dysphoria might not be a false belief, but an accurate sensing that their embodied experience does not match the pattern most people experience. The person's internal sense of sexual self might actually align more closely with the opposite biological sex because their neurology was shaped by unusual hormone exposure. This is what the medical literature is increasingly showing. Not all dysphoria has the same cause, not all dysphoria is purely psychological, not all dysphoria is rooted in ideology; some dysphoria appears to have legitimate biological roots.

This is what pastorally careful thinking looks like. You do not dismiss dysphoria as sin. You do not assume that dysphoria is always rooted in trauma or social contagion or depression, though it sometimes is. You do not pretend that the body is always a reliable indicator of what the deeper sexual variation might be. You recognize that sexual difference is complex, that dysphoria is real suffering, and that the cause of that suffering might be

A pastor should help a family think through hard questions. Is this dysphoria longstanding or recent? Is it consistent across contexts, or does it come and go? Has something happened in this person's life that might be influencing how they think about their body? Are there other conditions, depression, anxiety, autism, trauma, that might be primary? Are peers in this person's life also experiencing gender questioning? Is the media diet filled with gender content that might be providing frameworks for understanding other kinds of distress? These questions are not dismissive. They are what careful discernment looks like, honoring the person experiencing dysphoria while refusing to assume that the person has perfect insight into what is causing their own distress.

The gospel does not promise that asking these questions will resolve dysphoria quickly. The gospel promises something different: you are made in God's image; your suffering is real; your confusion is understandable; your body is good, even when it feels broken; your identity is rooted in Christ, not in whether your body feels aligned with your internal sense of self. Peace comes not from fixing your body but from accepting it and living faithfully within it. That is the word the church should speak. Not ideology. Not dismissal. Wisdom

APPLICATION: WHAT THIS MEANS FOR THE CHURCH

If Genesis 1:27 teaches us that sexual difference is good and that both male and female image God equally, what does that mean for how the church responds to someone identifying as transgender? First, it means we have to stop reducing people to an ideology. Whether someone is affirming everything about a person's gender identity or denying the reality of their experience, the church has largely failed at seeing the person, making them a representative of a position rather than a human being made in God's image.

Second, it means we have to do deeper theological work than we have done. We cannot just cite Genesis 1:27 and consider the conversation over; we have to ask harder questions. What does it mean to embrace your biological sex when that sex feels foreign to you? What does it mean to be at peace in a body? How do we distinguish between spiritual growth and capitulation to suffering? What does the church owe someone in genuine dysphoria?

Third, it means we have to see sexual difference as a gift without making conformity to it an idol. Sexual difference matters, but if someone cannot align with their biological sex, that does not make them less made in God's image; it makes them someone who needs the church's help thinking through their identity at a deeper level than gender alone. Fourth, it means we have to hold both things at once: sexual difference is real and good, and some people experience their body in ways that feel contrary to

Genesis 1:27 is not a dismissal. It is an invitation to think more carefully, to love more sacrificially, and to do the theological work that most churches have been too afraid or too certain to do. The verse stands. Male and female He created them. Sexual difference is real. Both image God equally. And the person in front of you, regardless of how they experience their gender, is made in that image. The question the church has to answer is: what do we owe them because of that?

CHAPTER 2

WHAT IS GENDER DYSPHORIA?

*What gender dysphoria is, what the science
shows, and what Christians need to understand
about the suffering behind it*

A fifteen-year-old sits across from her parents. She is not crying, and she is not angry; she is explaining, with a clarity that terrifies them, why she wants to transition. Her parents nod. They say they love her, and they mean it, and they are also entirely lost. They love their daughter. Or do they. If she says she is a boy, is she still their daughter, and if they do not call her by the name she chose, are they rejecting her or protecting her.

She says it feels wrong to be in her body. She says she has felt this way since childhood. She says the dysphoria is unbearable.

Her parents do not know what dysphoria is. They do not know whether it is a medical condition, a spiritual problem, or a symptom of depression; they do not know whether affirming her identity will help her or harm her; they do not know what to do. This is the situation facing

*The suffering is real even if every
response to that suffering is not wise.*

What you need is not ideology but information. You need to understand what gender dysphoria actually is—clinically, psychologically, spiritually—and to distinguish between gender dysphoria, gender identity, and gender ideology. You need to know what the science says and what it does not say. And you need to understand why the suffering is real even if every response to that suffering is not wise.

DEFINING GENDER DYSPHORIA: THE CLINICAL REALITY

The Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM-5) defines Gender Dysphoria in children as "a marked incongruence between one's experienced/expressed gender and assigned gender, lasting at least 6 months, manifesting by at least six of the following criteria." Those criteria include a strong desire to be the other gender; a strong preference for cross-gender clothing and games; a strong preference for playmates of the other gender; a strong desire to participate in the stereotypical games and pastimes of the other gender; a strong desire to have the physical sex characteristics of the other gender; a strong desire to urinate in the sitting

For adolescents and adults, the criteria shift, moving toward the incongruence between experienced or expressed gender and assigned gender, where the person experiences significant distress or impairment in functioning. The threshold is otherwise the same: at least six months in duration, and distress that is clinically significant.

Here is what matters. Gender dysphoria is listed in the DSM-5 as a mental health condition, but that does not mean it is a mental illness in the sense of being a psychological distortion; it means that it causes measurable distress and impairment. It is not trivial. It is not, in most cases, a phase. It requires clinical attention.

And yet—this is crucial—the existence of gender dysphoria as a diagnosis does not settle what causes it or what the best response to it is. The diagnosis names the phenomenon; it does not explain the phenomenon; and it certainly does not prescribe the treatment. This is where the church has gone wrong, treating dysphoria either as if it does not exist, a cruelty disguised as conviction, or accepting every medical intervention offered as the obvious next step, an affirmation disguised as compassion. Neither is correct.

DYSPHORIA, IDENTITY, AND IDEOLOGY: THREE DIFFERENT THINGS

Before we go further, we need to make distinctions. Gender dysphoria is a psychological experience of distress related to the incongruence between one's experienced

Gender identity is a person's internal sense of their own gender—how someone experiences themselves as male, female, or something else—and it is different from dysphoria. Some people have a strong sense of a gender identity that differs from their assigned sex but experience minimal dysphoria; some experience significant dysphoria without having a clear alternate gender identity. The relationship between the two is not as simple as "different identity equals dysphoria."

Gender ideology is a set of claims about what gender is, what gender means, and how gender should be understood in society, and this is where the distinction becomes important. A person can experience dysphoria and search for identity without accepting gender ideology as the explanation for what is happening; and a society can accept gender ideology without accepting that it correctly describes the experience of all people with dysphoria.

The church has largely failed to make these distinctions, treating all three as if they were the same thing—one phenomenon that must be either rejected entirely or accepted entirely. In reality they are three separate questions. A person can be experiencing real dysphoria (true), be searching for a gender identity that fits them better (true), and still be embracing an ideological understanding of what gender is that does not account for the full complexity of human existence (also possible and true).

Compassion for someone's dysphoria does not require accepting gender ideology. But denying the reality of

WHAT THE SCIENCE SHOWS AND DOES NOT SHOW

This is where we have to be careful, because the science on gender dysphoria is real but incomplete. Some facts are solid, others are contested, and most are more complex than either side of the political debate acknowledges.

What the science clearly shows is this: gender dysphoria exists; its prevalence has increased significantly, particularly among adolescent assigned females; the distress is measurable and real; and people experiencing dysphoria have elevated rates of depression, anxiety, and suicidal ideation. Let that land. Young people experiencing dysphoria have suicide rates the church cannot ignore. This is not a small thing, and it is not something to dismiss—not evidence that we should do whatever the person wants, but evidence that we should not mock them, dismiss them, or refuse them pastoral care.

What the science shows less clearly is the cause. Some research suggests biological factors such as prenatal hormone exposure, neurological differences, and genetic factors; some suggests psychological or social factors; most suggests it is the result of many factors at once. We do not actually know the primary cause, and pretending we do is false certainty in either direction.

On outcomes, the picture is just as varied. Some people who experience dysphoria in childhood desist by adulthood, particularly if assigned female; some persist

And on medical interventions: puberty blockers pause puberty, allowing time for exploration before irreversible changes; hormones produce physical changes; surgery is irreversible. But the long-term outcomes of these interventions are not fully studied. We do not have decades of data on how people fare who began medical transition in adolescence—this is the honest truth. We have anecdotal reports and shorter-term studies, but we do not have the longitudinal data we would have for other medical interventions affecting people for decades.

This is not an argument against medical transition. It is an argument for medical precision, informed consent, careful psychological evaluation, and age-appropriate decision-making. The church has largely failed on all of those fronts, saying either "medically transition if you want, no questions" or "never medically transition under any circumstances." Both are failures of care.

THE SUFFERING IS REAL

This needs to be named clearly. The person experiencing gender dysphoria is not making it up; they are not confused about what they are experiencing; they are experiencing real distress. A fifteen-year-old assigned female at birth who experiences her developing chest as a violation of her body is not being dramatic—she is suffering. A person who has persistent dysphoria into adulthood is not being trendy—they are struggling. When they describe their body as feeling at its core wrong, that

This is where many churches have failed. We have treated dysphoria as if it were not real because we did not understand it; we have responded to people in distress with dismissal instead of care; we have made the gospel sound like it does not take seriously the suffering of people in our own congregations. That has to change.

Taking someone's dysphoria seriously does not mean affirming everything they decide to do about it. Parents take a child's depression seriously without affirming every decision the depressed child makes; pastors take someone's addiction seriously without supporting every behavior that addiction produces. Taking dysphoria seriously means acknowledging that the suffering is real, refusing to mock it, and walking with the person through it—not abandoning them into ideology.

CHILDREN, ADOLESCENTS, AND THE MEDICAL QUESTION

This is the most complicated part, and the church has largely avoided doing the work. When a child says they are the other gender, parents panic. Schools now have policies requiring the use of preferred names and pronouns; therapy can be hard to find because many therapists feel pressure to affirm quickly without exploring; some states have laws protecting social transition for children while others restrict medical interventions. Everyone is afraid, and nobody is doing the careful, patient work.

Here is what we know: gender dysphoria in childhood does not always persist into adulthood. Studies show that 60–90% of children who meet criteria for gender

The question the church should ask is this: how do we care for children experiencing dysphoria in a way that does not assume it will persist, does not assume it will not, and does not push in either direction? Some children benefit from social transition—changing names, presentation, and pronouns—and for some this is experienced as relief, while for others it increases dysphoria. The outcomes are not uniform. This is not a simple intervention.

Most children do not need immediate medical intervention. Puberty blockers have been used, but their long-term effects are not fully understood; hormones create irreversible changes; surgery is not typically done on minors except in rare circumstances. The question is not whether these interventions exist. The question is when they are appropriate, who should make the decision, and what informed consent actually looks like for a teenager.

The church's responsibility is not to make these decisions. It is to help families think carefully, to refuse to mock the child's suffering, to refuse to pretend we have certainty we do not have, and to walk alongside families as they handle impossibly complicated terrain.

THE DETRANSITION REALITY

There is something the affirming side of this debate rarely acknowledges clearly: some people transition and

Why would someone transition and later regret it? The reasons vary. Some realized their dysphoria was related to trauma or other mental health issues that needed different treatment; some transitioned under pressure from affirmative communities and later reconsidered; some found that medical transition did not solve the underlying dysphoria; some regretted the social consequences or the irreversible medical changes; some simply changed their minds about their gender identity.

This is not proof that transition is always wrong. It is proof that transition is not always right for everyone, and it means the church has a responsibility to help people think carefully before making irreversible decisions. What the church should not do is use detransitioners as a rhetorical weapon to dismiss all transition. What it should do is acknowledge that some people's best path includes transition and some does not—and that the work is discerning which is true for each person.

WHAT GENDER DYSPHORIA TEACHES US

If we take gender dysphoria seriously as a clinical and pastoral reality, what does it teach us? First, it teaches us that the human experience of gender is complex; not everyone experiences gender in a straightforward way, and this is not a new discovery, though it is one we have largely ignored. Second, it teaches us that suffering is real—some people experience genuine distress about their bodies and their gender, and that suffering deserves a

Third, it teaches us that we do not have all the answers. The science is incomplete, the theology is underdeveloped, the pastoral care frameworks are inadequate—and admitting this is not weakness but honesty. Fourth, it teaches us that precision matters: using the word dysphoria carelessly, using it to describe everyone who questions their gender, using it to dismiss the reality of medical conditions—all of this prevents us from thinking clearly.

Fifth, it teaches us that ideology, on both sides, obscures rather than clarifies. When we treat dysphoria as entirely biological or entirely psychological or entirely social, we miss the complexity; when we make it primarily a political issue, we abandon the person; when we make it primarily a spiritual issue, we miss the real suffering. The truth involves all dimensions of human existence.

APPLICATION: WHAT THE CHURCH SHOULD DO

If the church takes gender dysphoria seriously, what does that mean in practice? First, it means refusing to mock people experiencing dysphoria; if someone says they are suffering, the pastoral response is not dismissal but "Tell me more. How can I help?" Second, it means creating space for people to ask questions. Many people struggling with dysphoria have never had a pastor or counselor ask them careful, compassionate questions—when did you start feeling this way, what does it feel like, what have you tried, what do you think this means—and these are the questions that help people think rather than the ones that push them toward ideology.

Fifth, it means doing the theological work. We need a theology of the body, a theology of identity, a theology of suffering, a theology of what it means to be made in God's image—all of it held together. Not theology that dismisses dysphoria and not theology that affirms ideology uncritically, but theology that takes both the suffering and the truth seriously.

Gender dysphoria is not a simple thing. It is not a simple sin; it is not a simple medical condition; it is a human being in distress about the most fundamental aspects of their existence, and the church owes them something more than mockery or uncritical affirmation. The church owes them care. The church owes them truth. The church owes them space to think. And the church owes them the refusal to reduce them to a debate. This is what taking gender dysphoria seriously means.

**THE CASS REVIEW AND MEDICAL
CAUTION AROUND THE WORLD**

Then, in 2024, Hilary Cass, a renowned pediatrician, released the findings of a three-year review of gender care for children in the UK. The Cass Review examined thousands of cases, interviewed practitioners, reviewed research, and came to conclusions that complicated the affirming narrative. Cass found that the evidence base for medical interventions in young people with gender dysphoria is weak, that psychological evaluation is often inadequate, that the speed of transition is often too rapid, and that social contagion may be playing a role in the increase in cases, particularly among assigned females.

Most importantly, Cass concluded: "The evidence for the dramatic increase in numbers of children presenting with gender dysphoria is unclear. Many of these young people have other vulnerabilities—trauma, neurodivergence, mental health conditions. These are not being adequately explored before moving toward medical transition." The review did not say "never use medical interventions." It said: slow down, think carefully, ensure that psychological evaluation is thorough, and consider whether there are other explanations for the dysphoria. This is where the Western world's medical consensus is moving—not toward prohibition, but toward caution.

Sweden, in 2023, made a similar move. The Swedish

A Christian parent needs to understand that the medical establishment itself is becoming more cautious. If your doctor is recommending rapid medical transition without extensive psychological evaluation, your doctor may be out of step with the emerging consensus in pediatric medicine. This does not mean transition is always wrong. It means: ask questions, request psychological evaluation, seek second opinions, and do not assume that what is being recommended is the obvious next step. Ensure that your child has actually been evaluated for other explanations—trauma, depression, peer influence, autism spectrum, other mental health conditions. The emerging medical caution should inform the church's caution, not as a political statement, but as a pastoral one grounded in medical reality.

THE MEDICAL NUMBERS AND WHAT THEY TELL US

The statistics on gender clinic referrals are stark enough that they cannot be dismissed as simply better access to care. The numbers are too dramatic, the rise too sudden, and the trajectory tells a story that demands serious examination. In 2009, the NHS in the UK received approximately 77 new referrals to gender identity clinics;

Australia experienced similar trajectories, with referrals to gender clinics increasing roughly tenfold in less than a decade; Spain reported similar patterns; Canada reported similar patterns. This is not localized, and it is not regional—it is happening across multiple developed countries simultaneously. The pattern raises a simple question: did the prevalence of gender dysphoria actually increase this dramatically, or did something else change?

There are several possible explanations. It is possible that prevalence genuinely increased this dramatically—perhaps increasing social acceptance made it safer for people with dysphoria to present to clinics, perhaps social media and internet communities made it easier for dysphoric people to find information and community, perhaps the shift was simply from hiding dysphoria to expressing it. This is plausible. Social permission matters; a person who has experienced dysphoria but was afraid to say anything might become willing to say it once they believe they will be accepted rather than rejected.

But there are other possible explanations, and the medical establishment in multiple countries is taking them seriously. Sweden's national health board, in 2023, published a detailed analysis of why it was becoming more cautious. Its conclusion was that while there are young people with genuine, persistent dysphoria who benefit from medical intervention, the recent surge in referrals

This does not mean dysphoria is not real for those experiencing it. It means that the rapid rise in numbers suggests something else is happening alongside genuine dysphoria—either social influence is playing a significant role in whether dysphoria is expressed and acted upon, or identification with gender variance has become a more available structure for expressing other kinds of distress, or some combination of both.

The Cass Review in the UK, released in 2024, made this explicit. The review was commissioned to examine the care of transgender and gender-nonconforming children and young people in the NHS; it involved three years of work, interviews with hundreds of practitioners and parents, examination of thousands of cases, and careful review of the research literature. Hilary Cass, the renowned pediatrician who led the review, concluded: "The evidence that the numbers of young people presenting with gender dysphoria reflects a genuine increase in prevalence of gender dysphoria is uncertain." Not rejected. Uncertain. She found that psychological evaluation was often inadequate, that the speed of medical transition was often too rapid, and that alternative

Cass wrote: "Many of these young people have other vulnerabilities that are not being adequately recognized and addressed. There is no strong research on the long-term outcomes of early social transition. There is insufficient evidence on the safety and efficacy of puberty blockers in this context." What did she recommend? Not prohibition of medical transition, but caution: thorough psychological evaluation; the exploration of trauma, depression, neurodivergence, and peer influence; slower timelines; more conservative use of puberty blockers and hormones until the evidence is clearer; and space for young people to explore identity without rushing toward permanent medical changes.

This is important because the affirming narrative in the West has claimed that science clearly supports early medical transition, and that claim is increasingly contested by pediatricians, psychiatrists, and health policy makers in multiple countries—not by religious conservatives, but by medical professionals trained to evaluate evidence and committed to the welfare of young people. A Christian parent should understand that the medical field itself is divided, and that the countries most experienced in treating gender dysphoria over the longest periods are now questioning the speed and breadth of medical interventions. The Netherlands pioneered the Dutch Protocol; now Dutch clinicians are reconsidering. The UK pioneered the Gender Identity Service for adolescents; now UK pediatricians are recommending more caution. Sweden developed expertise; now Sweden is

If your doctor is recommending rapid transition without extensive psychological work, your doctor may be out of step with what international medical consensus is moving toward. This does not mean your doctor is wrong. It means: ask questions, seek second opinions, request psychological evaluation before medical decisions, request information about long-term outcomes, and ask what research supports the proposed timeline. The medical uncertainty should inform your caution as a parent. This is not religious ideology; it is medical realism. The evidence is genuinely unclear, the outcomes are genuinely unknown, and the long-term consequences of early medical transition are not yet fully understood.

A pastor should understand something similar. You are not qualified to make medical decisions, but you are qualified to encourage families to slow down, to think carefully, to get thorough evaluation, and to consider whether there are other explanations for what a young person is experiencing. You are not rejecting the young person by encouraging this; you are being responsible with a young person's future. You are not saying "do not transition." You are saying: do not rush, take time, get help understanding what you are experiencing, consider what else might be causing this distress. The gospel does not require you to defer to any particular medical protocol; the gospel requires wisdom, care, and the refusal to rush toward irreversible decisions made under pressure.

A young person in dysphoria needs time. They need professional evaluation, they need community, they need to be known and loved—and they do not need quick medical fixes; they need slow, careful discernment. The

The problem is not medical intervention itself. The problem is medical intervention without adequate psychological evaluation; the problem is speed without discernment; the problem is assuming that dysphoria has only one cause and one solution. A medical professional who is cautious has learned from experience—they have seen outcomes, they have watched young people who transitioned and later expressed regret, they have watched young people who transitioned and felt genuine relief, they have watched young people with depression masquerading as dysphoria, they have watched young people with trauma creating disconnection from their body. The caution is not based in fear. It is based in clinical experience, and that is worth taking seriously.

You as a pastor can say to a family: "The medical establishment itself is becoming more cautious about this. That does not mean you should avoid medical help. It means you should seek medical professionals who are thoughtful, who do thorough evaluation, who are willing to slow down." That is a word worth speaking.

CHAPTER 3

THE BODY MATTERS

*A biblical theology of embodiment – why the
incarnation and resurrection make the body
good, not disposable*

There is a moment in every church that tells you what it actually believes about the body, and it is the moment you watch someone receive Communion. The pastor places a small piece of bread in their mouth and says the old words: "The body of Christ, broken for you." Not a symbol of the body. The body.

*Christianity teaches something
subversive: the body matters.*

This is where Christian theology separates itself from every other religious tradition. Christianity is not Gnostic; it does not treat the body as an obstacle to the spirit, and it does not teach that the real you is trapped inside a flesh prison, waiting for escape. It teaches something subversive instead: the body matters.

Now we see only a reflection as in a mirror; then we shall see face to face.

– 1 CORINTHIANS 13:12

We will be embodied in eternity. The body is not temporary, not incidental; it is where human existence happens, and the church has largely forgotten this. The forgetting has enormous implications for how we think about gender, about dysphoria, about the relationship between identity and embodiment — and if we get it wrong, we will fail people in genuine pain.

GOD BECAME FLESH: THE INCARNATION AND THE BODY

Start here, with the words John chose to open his Gospel.

The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us.

– JOHN 1:14

Not a symbol. Not an illusion. Not a temporary descent into matter. Flesh — sarx — the actual, physical body of Jesus Christ, born of Mary, hungry, tired, vulnerable to pain. Why did God become flesh? For many reasons at

This matters because there is a very old heresy that wants to say the spirit is good and the body is evil, that the real self is separate from the physical, that matter is fallen in a way that demands we escape it. The heresy has a name. It is Gnosticism, and it shows up in different forms throughout history; it has deeply infected how Christians think about the body — particularly the sexual body, particularly the gendered body.

The Incarnation is God's definitive rejection of this heresy. God takes a body and calls it good; God says matter is not evil and flesh is not the enemy. The body is the way human existence happens, and God is willing to become body in order to redeem body. If the body is good — actually good, not reluctantly tolerated — then it matters. What you do with your body matters; how you treat your body matters; what you think about your body matters.

This is where contemporary gender ideology and Christian theology diverge. Gender ideology tends to treat the body as incidental to identity; it says your gender identity is who you are, your body is secondary, and if your body does not match your internal sense of self, then the body is the problem and not the identity. Christianity says something different. Your body is part of who you are — not a costume you can exchange, not a mistake to be corrected, but a gift to be inhabited, cared for, and lived from.

This does not mean your body determines everything about you, or that you have no agency regarding it, or that

THE RESURRECTION IS NOT ESCAPE

This is the second move, and it is where most Christians go wrong, because we have been trained to think of heaven as escape from the body. It is not. Paul writes it plainly.

For now we see only a reflection as in a mirror; then we shall see face to face. Now I know in part; then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known. And these three remain: faith, hope and love.

— 1 CORINTHIANS 13:12-13

Notice what Paul does not say. He does not say "Then I will escape my body" or "Then I will be pure spirit" or "Then matter will be gone." He says, "I shall see face to face." And a face requires a body. The Apostles' Creed makes the same confession: "I believe in the resurrection of the body." Not the resurrection of the spirit, separated from the body — the resurrection of the body. Jesus was raised bodily; he had a body that could be touched and that could eat. He was not a ghost. He was not pure spirit. He was embodied.

The promise to those who follow Christ is the same: resurrection of the body. We will have real bodies in eternity — not incidental bodies, but bodies that matter. This has enormous implications. If your destiny is embodied, if you will have a body forever, if resurrection is not escape but transformation, then what you think about your body now matters, how you treat it now matters,

It is not about conforming to social pressure. It is about understanding that embodied existence is not temporary, not a phase, not something to escape; it is the mode of existence God created you for, is redeeming you through, and will resurrect you in. If someone is experiencing dysphoria — a deep sense that their body is wrong — that is a real problem, but the problem is not the body itself. The problem is the suffering related to the body, and the solution is not pretending the body is irrelevant. The solution is learning to inhabit and be at peace in the body you have. This is hard. This is costly. And it is different from both the cruelty of "just accept it" and the denial of "your body is not real."

THE SHADOW OF GNOSTICISM

This is where we have to name something directly: gender ideology, as it is typically articulated, is Gnostic. It teaches that the real self is separate from the physical body, that your identity is a matter of internal feeling rather than external reality, that if your body does not match your sense of self the body is the problem and not the identity. This is the ancient heresy the church spent centuries fighting.

Gnosticism taught that matter is evil, that the body is a prison, that the real self is the spirit trapped inside flesh — and that to be saved is to escape the body and achieve a purely spiritual existence. Christianity rejected this completely. The body is good; the body is not a prison; embodied existence is not shameful; redemption is not escape from the body but transformation of the body.

But Gnosticism does not appear only in ancient

Here is what is tricky, though: Gnosticism appeals to real suffering. If someone is experiencing dysphoria — a deep sense that their body is wrong — then saying "your body is good and you need to accept it" sounds cruel. It sounds like we are denying their suffering. We are not. But we are refusing to solve the suffering by pretending the body is irrelevant.

THE TRUTH ABOUT DYSPHORIA AND THE BODY

Let's be clear about what we are claiming. We are not claiming that dysphoria is not real, that the suffering is insignificant, that someone who experiences deep dysphoria should just "accept it" and be fine. What we are claiming is that the correct response to dysphoria is not to pretend the body is not real; the correct response is to help someone find peace in their actual body while taking seriously the psychological and spiritual roots of the dysphoria.

This is hard. It is not simple, and it does not work the same way in every case. But it is the Christian response, because it is grounded in a theology that says the body is good, that God created your body, that your body will be

Now, some people reading this will say: "But you do not understand dysphoria. You have never felt this way. You are being cruel." I hear that, and I take it seriously. But cruelty would be to tell someone their body is not real, or to affirm their pain by pretending they can escape their body through gender transition; cruelty would be to offer a false solution to a problem that requires deeper work. True pastoral care says something else: "Your suffering is real. Your dysphoria is real. And the answer is not to pretend your body is irrelevant. The answer is to find your way to peace with the body you have, to understand the roots of your dysphoria, and to build an identity that goes deeper than gender."

This requires courage. It requires refusing to take the easy path of either cruelty or false affirmation. It requires staying in the tension, honoring both the suffering and the truth of the body.

WHAT BODY THEOLOGY MEANS PRACTICALLY

If the body matters — actually matters, not just theologically but practically — what does that mean? First, it means we stop treating the body as incidental. The way you eat, the way you sleep, the way you move, the way you care for your physical health: these are not trivial, because they are the way you live. The body is not a vehicle for a disembodied self. The body is you.

Second, it means we take seriously the reality of biological sex. The fact that you have a body that developed in a particular way, that is capable of particular

Fourth, it means we take dysphoria seriously as a problem to solve, not a problem to enable. If someone is experiencing deep distress about their body, the pastoral response is not to tell them the body is irrelevant; it is to help them understand why they are experiencing dysphoria, to address the psychological and spiritual roots, and to help them find their way to being at peace in their actual, embodied existence. This is not the same as forcing someone to accept their body against their will. It is deeper, longer, harder work — it is therapy, it is prayer, it is discipleship, it is learning to live from the inside out rather than constantly rebelling against the material reality of your existence.

This is where the gospel gets interesting. In every version of Christianity that is worth anything, there is a call to surrender: to die to yourself, to lose your life to find it, to give up your agenda for God's agenda. This is deeply uncomfortable, and it is not what the world teaches. The world teaches you to pursue what makes you happy, to demand that reality conform to your desires, to build an identity around your preferences and feelings. Christianity teaches something harder: sometimes reality is not what

This is not easy. This is not comfortable. This is not therapy-speak about validating feelings and honoring the self. But it is the path that leads to actual freedom. If you are constantly at war with your body, constantly resisting your physical reality, constantly trying to force your embodied existence into a different shape, you will exhaust yourself; you will find no peace; you will keep chasing interventions that promise relief but deliver only a different form of suffering. But if you can surrender, if you can accept your actual, embodied existence, if you can find peace with the body you have been given — that is where freedom lives. Not in pretending your body is not real. In accepting that it is real and learning to live from that ground.

For someone experiencing dysphoria, this is a costly path. It is not the affirmation that culture offers, and it is not the denial that churches offer; it is something harder and more real — acceptance of your actual existence, combined with the help, the prayer, the community, the counseling that makes that acceptance possible. This is what body theology actually teaches. Not "your body is a prison." Not "your body is irrelevant." But that your body matters, your body is good, your body is where your real life happens, and learning to be at peace in it is the path to actual freedom. The church needs to teach this again, and it needs to offer to people in dysphoria not what culture offers or what cruelty offers, but what the gospel offers: a way home to their own embodied existence.

N.T. Wright has done similar work with the doctrine of resurrection. Wright argues that the Christian hope is not escape from the body but resurrection of the body, and that the resurrected body is not a different body — it is the same body, transformed and renewed. This matters for how the church thinks about dysphoria. The church should offer not escape from the body but reconciliation with the body; not denial of the body but acceptance of it; not transformation of the body through medical intervention but transformation of the relationship to the body through grace. The gnostic heresy treats the body as an obstacle to the spirit; the Christian truth treats the body as the vehicle through which the spirit lives. To be at peace

This is costly. It is not the comfort that either ideology offers. But it is the path that leads to actual peace — not escape, but integration. Gnosticism sounds compassionate; it says, "Your body is the problem. Escape from it." But escape is not possible. You cannot escape your body; you can only deny it or accept it. Denying it creates constant war with yourself. Accepting it creates the possibility of peace. This is what body theology from the Christian tradition offers — not ideology, but wisdom earned through two thousand years of Christians learning to be at peace in their actual, embodied existence.

WHY BOTH PROGRESSIVE AND CONSERVATIVE GENDER VIEWS GO GNOSTIC

The greatest heresy infiltrating contemporary Christianity is not about gender specifically. It is about the body. Gnosticism — the ancient belief that the physical world is evil and the spiritual world is the only reality — has returned in new forms, and the church, caught between two ideological poles, has failed to name the heresy that underlies them both.

On the progressive side, the gnostic belief sounds like this: your true self is your internal sense of identity, and your body is a container that may or may not match that true self. The true you is interior — consciousness, identity, the sense of who you are — and the body is external, a temporary vessel that houses that self. If the container does not match your sense of self, the container can and should be changed to match your internal reality.

On the conservative side, the gnostic belief sounds different but is still present: your body is fallen and corrupted, your desires are disordered, what you feel about your body is unreliable, you cannot trust your internal experience, and you must discipline your body, deny its desires, and submit to what Scripture and tradition say the body is supposed to be. The body is dangerous; the body lies to you; your feelings are not trustworthy. This also treats the body as secondary – but instead of privileging the internal sense of self over the body, it privileges external authority over the internal sense of self. Either way, the body is not accepted as the integrated reality of who you are; the body is viewed with suspicion, something to be controlled rather than inhabited. This is Gnosticism too. It is the Gnosticism of contempt for the flesh rather than the Gnosticism of exaltation of consciousness, but it is Gnosticism. It says the body is not quite right, not quite acceptable, that it needs to be brought into line with something outside of itself.

Paul offers something radically different. He does not treat the body as a container, and he does not treat it as something to be controlled or escaped; he treats it as

Do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit, who is in you, whom you have received from God?

— 1 CORINTHIANS 6:19

The body is not a temple that houses the spirit. Your body is the temple. The physical and the spiritual are integrated. In the same passage, Paul writes the command that follows from it.

Therefore honor God with your bodies.

— 1 CORINTHIANS 6:20

Not "deny your bodies." Not "escape your bodies." Not "transcend your bodies." Honor them. Accept them. Inhabit them. This is what the incarnation teaches: God did not send a divine spirit into a body as temporary housing. God became embodied. Jesus is not a spirit trapped in flesh; Jesus is spirit and body. He ate, he had wounds, he was touched and touched others, he had embodied relationships, he experienced embodied life.

The resurrection is not escape from the body. It is transformation of the body.

We know that when he appears, we shall be like him, for we shall see him as he is.

— 1 JOHN 3:2

Like Christ. And Christ in resurrection is embodied — not a ghost, not pure consciousness, but a body. Paul says it again to the Corinthians.

Listen, I tell you a mystery: We will not all sleep, but

– 1 CORINTHIANS 15:51-52

The body is raised. Not escaped. Transformed. To accept your body — even when that body creates suffering — is not to deny the spirit; it is to follow the pattern Christ established. Integration. Acceptance. Transformation of how you relate to your embodied existence rather than escape from that existence.

Both progressive and conservative gender ideology fail at this point, and both are, at their core, Gnostic. Both assume the body is not quite acceptable as it is; both believe the body needs to be fixed. The progressive ideology says fix it by aligning it with your internal sense of self; the conservative ideology says fix it by submitting it to external doctrine about what the body should be. Neither offers the hard, Christian path. That path is this: your body is good, your body is created by God, your body is the vehicle through which you encounter reality, your body is how you love and are loved, your body will be resurrected and transformed — and in the meantime your calling is not to escape your body or to perfect it or to make it match your internal sense of self, but to accept your body and to live faithfully within it.

This is not easy. It is not comfortable. It does not promise that you will feel good about your body. It promises something harder and deeper — integration; peace that comes not from fixing the body but from accepting it and living out of that acceptance. The disabled

This is what separates the gospel from ideology on both sides. The gospel does not promise to make your body what you want; it promises that you are loved in your body, that you are made in God's image in your body, that your body is good, that transformation happens not by escaping embodied existence but by inhabiting it with faith. This is why the church has to recover body theology — not a theology that says the body is fallen and must be denied, not a theology that says the body does not matter and the internal sense of self is all that matters, but a theology that says you are embodied, your body is good, your body is part of your identity, your peace comes not from changing the body but from accepting it and living faithfully within it, and your hope comes from the promise that this embodied existence, with all its suffering and difficulty, will be redeemed and transformed by God. This is what separates the gospel from ideology on both sides.

CHAPTER 4

EUNUCHS IN THE BIBLE

What Matthew 19:12, Isaiah 56, and the Ethiopian eunuch teach about belonging beyond the typical pattern

There is a verse that almost nobody brings up in the gender conversation, and the fact that it is almost never cited tells you everything you need to know about how the church has been thinking about this question. It is Matthew 19:12. Jesus is answering a question about divorce; He teaches about the permanence of marriage, and then His disciples respond, "If this is the situation between a husband and wife, it is better not to marry."

Not everyone can accept this word, but only those to whom it has been given. For there are eunuchs who were born that way; and there are eunuchs who have been made that way by others; and there are those who choose to live like eunuchs for the sake of the kingdom of heaven. The one who can accept this

— MATTHEW 19:12

This is the only passage where Jesus directly addresses people who are not typically male or female in the biological sense, and what He says is striking. He acknowledges that eunuchs exist; He acknowledges that there are different kinds of eunuchs; He includes them in His moral universe, and He offers them a place in the kingdom of God based on how they live, not based on whether they fit the typical pattern. This passage has been almost entirely ignored by the church when discussing gender. We have preferred to work from Genesis 1:27 alone, as if that verse were sufficient to address every variation of human experience.

Eunuch theology opens a door that the church has refused to walk through.

It is not sufficient. And eunuch theology—biblical theology of eunuchs—opens a door that the church has refused to walk through.

WHAT MATTHEW 19:12 ACTUALLY SAYS: THREE KINDS OF EUNUCHS

Look at the verse carefully: "For there are eunuchs who were born that way; and there are eunuchs who have been made that way by others; and there are those who choose to live like eunuchs for the sake of the kingdom of heaven." Jesus identifies three categories of eunuchs.

Second, eunuchs made that way by others. This refers to people who were castrated—sometimes as slaves, sometimes as part of court practice, sometimes for religious reasons in various cultures. Jesus acknowledges that some people's sexual capacity has been altered by human action; He does not affirm the practice of castration, but He acknowledges the reality that some people exist outside the typical pattern not because of their own choice but because of what has been done to them.

Third, eunuchs who choose to live as eunuchs for the kingdom of heaven. This refers to people—likely the unmarried followers of Jesus—who renounce sexual activity and procreation for the sake of spiritual devotion. Jesus acknowledges that some people choose a life path that removes them from the typical reproductive pattern, and He affirms this as a valid choice if it is done for kingdom purposes.

What is Jesus doing here? He is saying that the pattern of male and female designed for procreation is real, but

ISAIAH 56 AND THE EUNUCH'S PROMISE

But there is even more in Scripture about eunuchs, and it is even more striking. Turn to Isaiah 56. This is post-exile Isaiah; the people have been restored to the land, Gentiles are coming to faith, and the borders of who belongs to God's people are being redrawn. And the prophet addresses eunuchs specifically.

To the eunuchs who keep my Sabbaths, who choose what pleases me and hold fast to my covenant—to them I will give within my temple and its walls a memorial and a name better than sons and daughters; I will give them an everlasting name that will endure forever.

— ISAIAH 56:4-5

Let that land. A eunuch—someone who cannot have biological children, someone who is outside the reproductive pattern—is promised something better than children: an everlasting name, a memorial, a place in God's house. In the ancient Near East, children were your legacy; your children would carry your name and your children would remember you, and without children, you

And God promises the eunuch a better legacy than biological children: an everlasting name, remembered not because of procreative capacity but because of faith. What is God doing here? God is saying that the pattern of procreation and biological family is real, but your value is not dependent on fitting that pattern; your place in God's kingdom is not earned through biological capacity, and your legacy comes through covenant faithfulness, not genetic inheritance. This is revolutionary. This is God saying: I see you. I know you are outside the pattern. And you are not outside My kingdom.

ACTS 8 AND THE ETHIOPIAN EUNUCH'S FULL INCLUSION

Now consider what happens in Acts 8. Philip, one of the apostles, meets an Ethiopian eunuch on the road; the eunuch is a person of authority in the Ethiopian court, holding high position, but he is also a eunuch—outside the typical sexual pattern. He is reading Isaiah, specifically Isaiah 53, about the suffering servant, and he asks Philip, "Tell me, please, who is the prophet talking about, himself or someone else?" Philip explains Jesus, the eunuch believes, and he asks, "Look, here is water. What can stop me from being baptized?" Philip baptizes him—full membership in God's people, full inclusion in the Church.

Notice what does not happen. Philip does not say, "Well, you need to understand that the standard for Christian membership is male and female. You are outside that pattern. So perhaps you should wait." He does not say,

What is the story saying? It is saying that the eunuch—the person outside the typical sexual pattern—has full access to God's kingdom: full membership, full belonging, no qualification. The story does not require the eunuch to become typically male or female; it does not require conformity to the pattern. It requires faith. It requires following Jesus. And that is enough.

WHAT EUNUCH THEOLOGY TEACHES US

So what does this teach, and what does it mean to have a biblical eunuch theology? First, it means acknowledging that sexual difference is a pattern, not an absolute. Genesis 1:27 describes the pattern—male and female, designed to be fruitful, designed to fill the earth; this is how God made human beings to work. But patterns have exceptions, all of them, and the Bible acknowledges eunuchs as exceptions to the pattern—not as mistakes, not as less-than, but as exceptions that exist within God's design.

Second, it means understanding that belonging to God's people is not dependent on fitting the sexual pattern. The eunuch's value is not dependent on reproductive capacity; the eunuch's place in God's kingdom is not earned through biological conformity. The eunuch belongs to God through covenant, through faith, through following Jesus.

Third, it means taking seriously that people exist outside the typical pattern. Not everyone is straightforwardly male or female; not everyone has typical

Fourth, it means refusing to make conformity to the sexual pattern the measure of who belongs and who does not. The eunuch was promised an everlasting name, a place in God's house, not because the eunuch became typically gendered, but because the eunuch kept covenant and held fast to God.

HOW THIS CHANGES THE TRANSGENDER CONVERSATION

So how does eunuch theology apply to the contemporary conversation about gender and transgender identity? This is where we have to be careful not to overstate, but also not to understate. Eunuch theology does not say that gender is completely fluid and anyone can be any gender they choose; the Bible still teaches that sexual difference is real and good, Genesis 1:27 still stands, male and female He created them. And eunuch theology does not say that transgender identity is the same as being a eunuch in Scripture; the conditions are not identical. The ancient eunuch was typically someone who could not engage in typical sexual reproduction, either from birth or through castration, and that is a different reality from modern transgender identity and gender dysphoria.

But eunuch theology does say something important: the Bible acknowledges that not everyone fits the typical pattern, the Bible does not treat people outside the pattern as less-than, the Bible includes them, the Bible promises them a place, and the Bible judges them by their faithfulness, not by whether they conform to the sexual

This is different from both dismissal and uncritical affirmation. It is not, "You are wrong about your gender and you need to accept your biological sex." It is, "Your experience of your gender is complex. Your belonging in God's community is not dependent on fitting a pattern. And we will walk with you in that complexity, not as judges but as fellow travelers who also do not always fit cleanly into categories." And it is not, "Whatever you think about your gender is true and the church should affirm everything you choose." It is, "Your suffering is real. Your experience of your body is real. And your value and your place in God's kingdom transcend your gender experience."

THE LIMIT OF THE ANALOGY

This is important to name: the eunuch analogy is not perfect, and pretending it is would be intellectually dishonest. A eunuch in Scripture was typically someone incapable of reproduction, either from birth or through external action, while a transgender person is typically someone with typical reproductive capacity who experiences their gender differently than their biological sex. These are not identical situations; the eunuch's condition was about reproductive capacity, and the

So we should not collapse the categories. We should not say that the Bible's theology of eunuchs fully addresses transgender identity, because it does not; the Bible does not directly address gender identity as we understand it now. But eunuch theology does give us something important: permission to acknowledge that not everyone fits the typical pattern, permission to include people who do not fit the pattern, and permission to judge people by their faithfulness, not by whether they conform to sexual norms. That permission changes everything.

WHAT THE CHURCH SHOULD LEARN

If the church takes eunuch theology seriously, what changes? First, it changes how we speak about gender. We stop pretending the binary is absolute; we acknowledge that sexual difference is a pattern, but patterns have exceptions, and not everyone fits neatly. Second, it changes how we include people. We stop making conformity to gender expectations a condition for belonging—the eunuch belonged not because he became typically gendered but because he kept covenant—and we include people who do not fit the pattern.

Third, it changes how we judge. We stop evaluating people's faithfulness based on whether they fit gender expectations; a eunuch's value was not his reproductive capacity, and a Christian's value is not their conformity to gender norms but their faithfulness to Christ. Fourth, it changes how we treat dysphoria. If someone is experiencing dysphoria, we do not dismiss them by saying

This does not mean affirming every choice someone makes about their body; it does not mean the church has no wisdom to offer about the body and gender and identity; it does not mean we pretend dysphoria is the same as just being an exception to the typical pattern. But it means we offer the same thing Isaiah offered the eunuch: you are outside the pattern, you will not have the legacy of children, but I will give you a name and a place in My house that will last forever. That is the promise. That is the gospel. Not conformity, but inclusion; not denial of the exception, but embrace of the exception into God's covenant people. The church has known this about eunuchs for 2,000 years. We just forgot. And remembering changes everything.

THE GALLI, THE HIJRA, AND WHAT HISTORY TEACHES

The eunuch theology of Matthew 19:12 is not without historical context. Jesus was not inventing something new; He was drawing on a reality that existed in multiple cultures and religions for centuries. In ancient Rome, the cult of Cybele included the galli—priests who were castrated and who lived outside typical male gender roles; they wore female dress, they adopted female names, and they were integrated into religious life in ways that were recognized and somewhat accepted. In Hindu and Islamic traditions across India, the hijra have existed for centuries; the hijra are people who are not considered

In various indigenous cultures, third-gender categories existed: the Two-Spirit people of Native American cultures, the fa'afafine of Samoa—people who existed outside the binary and had recognized social roles. This does not mean that these cultures had the same understanding of gender as contemporary culture; it means that humans have long recognized that some people exist outside the typical binary. Cultures have handled this recognition differently—some with respect, some with disrespect—but most human cultures have somehow acknowledged the reality.

What does this teach? First, that the impulse to fit everyone neatly into male or female is not universal; humans have often created social structures to account for people who do not fit the binary. Second, that when a culture does create space for people outside the binary, that space is often religious or spiritual—the galli were priests, the hijra have spiritual significance, the Two-Spirit people had ceremonial roles. This suggests something important: the human longing to understand gender and identity is not simply modern. It is ancient. And humans have often tried to address that longing through religious frameworks.

The church should understand this history not to affirm contemporary gender ideology, but to understand that the church's refusal to engage with people outside the gender binary is not inevitable; other religious traditions have found ways to include them. The question is not

THE EUNUCH'S PROMISE IN ISAIAH 56: WHAT LEGACY LOOKS LIKE BEYOND PROCREATION

Isaiah 56 contains one of the most subversive statements in Scripture about belonging and legacy: a eunuch—someone outside the reproductive pattern—is promised "a memorial and a name better than sons and daughters." In the ancient world, sons and daughters were your legacy; your children would carry your name and remember you, and without children, you were erased from history. But the eunuch is promised something different: an everlasting name, a memorial, a place in God's house.

What does this promise mean? First, it means the eunuch's value is not dependent on reproductive capacity; the eunuch does not have to apologize for not being able to have biological children, because the eunuch's life is

For someone experiencing dysphoria, this is important. The dysphoria often involves a sense of fundamental wrongness—"My body is wrong. I do not fit the pattern. I cannot participate in what my body is designed for." The eunuch theology says that your body may not fit the typical pattern and your role may be different, but your life still has meaning, and your legacy is not dependent on conforming to the reproductive pattern. A person who accepts their biological sex, even though they experience dysphoria, is not giving up on meaning; they are finding meaning in a different way—not through reproductive participation, but through spiritual participation, not through biological legacy, but through covenant faithfulness.

This is what Isaiah 56 promises, and it is what the church has largely failed to teach. The gospel is not a promise that you will feel comfortable in your body. The gospel is a promise that your body is good, that your identity goes deeper than gender, and that your legacy is found in covenant with God, not in whether you fit the biological pattern. That is a promise worth hearing.

CHAPTER 5

THE GENDER IDEOLOGY DEBATE

*Where Scripture agrees with and parts ways from
contemporary claims about sex, gender, and
identity*

Every conversation about gender eventually arrives at the same hidden fault line: a disagreement about what gender is. Is gender an innate, internal sense of identity that should be accepted and affirmed regardless of biological reality, or is it rooted in biological sex and shaped by cultural expectation? Is gender performance—roles, presentation, social norms—or is it identity? Is it a binary, or a spectrum? People answer these questions differently, and the differences matter.

The church's job is not to police every one of these questions. Its job is to think carefully about what Scripture teaches and to refuse to reduce the gospel to any single ideological answer. But the church also carries a responsibility to name where contemporary gender ideology parts ways with Christian theology—not to score political points, but because the stakes are souls. If an

*If ideology is promising what only the
gospel can deliver, the church has to
say so.*

WHAT GENDER IDEOLOGY CLAIMS

It helps to be specific about what the phrase even means. Gender ideology is a set of claims about the nature and meaning of gender, and while different versions exist, the core runs something like this. Gender is primarily an internal sense of identity—what matters most is the gender you feel you are, and your body is secondary. Gender is separate from biological sex; the two may or may not align, and when they do not, the felt identity is treated as more fundamental than the body. Gender is a spectrum or fluid rather than a binary, so that "male" and "female" become social constructs that fail to capture the full range of human experience, and people can be non-binary, genderfluid, or belong to categories that fit neither pole.

From those premises a prescription follows. If your gender identity does not align with your biological sex, you should transition—medically if necessary, socially if helpful—so that your external presentation and body match your internal sense of gender. And any expectation that asks a person to conform to norms based on biological sex is

Not everyone with questions about gender accepts all of these claims. But together they form what is typically called gender ideology—a comprehensive structure for understanding gender as internal identity, separate from biological reality, and deserving of social, medical, and legal support. The church has largely responded in one of two ways: rejecting all of it (cruelty disguised as conviction) or accepting all of it (capitulation disguised as compassion). Neither is the Christian response.

WHERE THE BIBLE AGREES

Before we talk about disagreement, honesty requires admitting where Scripture and gender ideology share some ground. The Bible teaches that people are more than their biological function; Genesis 1:27 says humans are made in the image of God, and that image is not genitalia but something deeper—representation, relationship, rule. So Scripture agrees that human identity reaches beyond mere biological category.

So God created man in his own image, in the image of God created he him; male and female created he them.

— GENESIS 1:27

The Bible also teaches that gender roles are cultural rather than absolute. It is not consistent in what it prescribes for male and female; Proverbs 31 describes a businesswoman and trader with real economic and social power, roles closed to women in many historical periods, which means Scripture itself refuses to lock gender roles

WHERE THE BIBLE PARTS WAYS WITH GENDER IDEOLOGY

The first parting concerns what is foundational. Gender ideology says your gender identity is who you are and your body is secondary, your internal sense of gender more fundamental than your biological reality. The Bible roots identity instead in being made in God's image; that is primary, and everything else—including gender—flows from it. Your body is not secondary, for it is the medium through which you live, but neither is it the absolute determinant of who you are. You are a person—body, mind, spirit—made in God's image. The claim is not "your body is who you are and you must accept it," but "you are a complete person, body and soul, and your identity is rooted in that whole reality, not in feeling alone and not in body alone."

The second parting concerns the nature of sexual difference. Gender ideology treats it as primarily a social construction—different cultures build gender differently, so the Bible's teaching about male and female is culturally conditioned and not universally binding. Scripture says

The third parting concerns dysphoria. Gender ideology says that if you experience your gender differently than your assigned sex, transition—medical, social, legal—is the path to relief. The Bible does not address dysphoria specifically, but it offers something else: the gospel. Your suffering is real and your dysphoria matters, and yet the answer is not to escape the body but to be transformed in mind, spirit, and your relationship to your embodied existence. The resurrection is not escape from the body; it is the body's transformation. The Christian path is learning to be at peace in your actual embodied reality—not cruel dismissal, but something harder and deeper than medical alteration or social pretense: genuine spiritual and psychological transformation that helps you be at peace with who you actually are.

The fourth parting concerns what freedom means. Gender ideology says freedom is the ability to express whatever gender you feel, to be affirmed, to access transition, to be called by your preferred name and pronouns. The Bible says freedom is freedom from sin, from the corruption that distorts human relationships and existence; it is reconciliation with God and with your own

THE LIMITS OF IDEOLOGY

Gender ideology promises more than it can deliver. It promises that if you transition, if you live as your true gender, the dysphoria will lift and you will finally be at peace. Sometimes that is true—some people transition and feel liberated. But others feel liberated at first and later experience regret, and others find that the dysphoria remains even after transition. The ideology promises a certainty the reality does not supply. The gospel makes a different promise: not that you will feel comfortable in your body, but that you will have a resurrection body, that your suffering will be redeemed, and that your identity will rest in something deeper than your gender experience. That is not the promise people want. It is the promise that delivers. The church's job is not to mock people for seeking comfort, but to offer them something better than ideology—a theological grid that takes seriously both their suffering and the deeper truth about who they are.

It is worth being specific about what neither side of the ideological divide can deliver. Left-leaning gender ideology promises that transition, life as your true gender, and an affirming community will make you happy and dissolve your dysphoria—a promise that does not always hold,

JUDITH BUTLER, JOHN MONEY, AND THE SEX-GENDER DISTINCTION

Contemporary gender ideology often traces its intellectual roots to Judith Butler and earlier theorists, and to understand the ideology you have to understand what these thinkers actually said—and how their ideas have been simplified and weaponized. In *Gender Trouble*, Butler argued that gender is performative: something we do, not something we are. She was arguing against the idea

John Money, a sexologist, coined the term "gender identity" in the 1950s, drawing a distinction between biological sex—chromosomes, anatomy, hormones—and the internal sense of being male or female. He did important work in recognizing that sexual development is complex and that people can develop atypically. But Money also conducted the infamous David Reimer experiment. Reimer was a boy whose penis was damaged in a circumcision accident; Money convinced the parents to raise the child as a girl, believing gender identity was purely socially constructed. Money was wrong. Reimer lived as a girl in constant distress, eventually transitioned back to living as a male, and in the end died by suicide. The case teaches that gender identity is not purely socially constructed—raising someone as a gender contrary to their sense of self creates deep distress—but it does not prove the opposite either. It means gender identity is complex.

Contemporary gender ideology has often taken Butler's

WHAT THE CHURCH SHOULD TEACH

If the church is going to respond faithfully, there are five things to say. First, affirm what is true in Scripture: sexual difference is real and created by God. Genesis 1:27 stands—male and female He created them. This is not

Third, name what the Bible does teach about the solution to dysphoria: not escape from the body but transformation through the gospel, not denial of suffering but its redemption, not medical alteration but spiritual and psychological healing that helps a person be at peace in their actual embodied existence. Fourth, insist that people are more than their gender—that more important than someone's gender identity is the fact that they bear God's image, more foundational than gender experience is a relationship with Jesus, and more ultimate than whether one feels comfortable in the body is whether one is at peace with God. Fifth, refuse the false choice. It is not affirm everything about gender ideology or show cruelty to people with dysphoria. There is a third way—truth-telling joined to genuine love, clear theology joined to pastoral care, refusing to reduce people to an ideology while also refusing to pretend ideology is gospel.

THE PASTORAL RESPONSE TO IDEOLOGY

How do we actually do this in the room with someone? If a person comes to you struggling with their gender, you do not start with ideology; you start with their suffering. Tell me what you are experiencing. How long has this been

You offer community, prayer, and counseling that is person-focused rather than ideology-driven; you offer time and space to think rather than pressure to move quickly toward transition. You refuse to affirm ideology while also refusing to be cruel. You say: I love you. Your suffering matters to me. And I believe there is a path toward healing that does not require you to reject your body or embrace ideology. Let's walk that path together. This is harder than either cruelty or capitulation. It is also the path that actually serves people.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The reason the church has to do this work is not political. It is pastoral. There are young people in dysphoria right now—genuine suffering, real confusion about body and gender—who need the church to offer something more than ideology on either side. They need to hear: You are made in God's image. Your suffering is real. And your answer is not to escape your body or to embrace an ideology that promises certainty about your gender. Your answer is the gospel—transformation, learning to be at peace in your actual embodied existence, finding your identity in Christ rather than in gender, learning to live in

The progressive side of this conversation makes a necessary claim: you cannot reduce a person to their biology. Body is not destiny. A woman is more than her reproductive capacity; a man is more than his testosterone. The claim is important—and incomplete. The conservative side makes its own necessary claim: body matters, it is not incidental to identity, the design of the body is not arbitrary, and male and female are not interchangeable categories but complementary realities with different kinds of meaning and responsibility. That claim is important too—and also incomplete. The progressive side, in pressing its truth, has often overreached: if biology does not determine destiny, then biology does not determine anything, the body reduced to a canvas for the self to decorate, the material reality of embodiment erased, the body treated as a choice rather than a given, with no room left for the question of what it means to live faithfully as an embodied creature. The conservative side has overreached in the mirror direction: if body matters, then body is destiny, the design of the body fixing the shape of a life, sex becoming not a category humans handle but a predetermined path they walk, the mystery of personhood erased, with no room for the person who experiences their body differently than others experience theirs. Both sides have gotten something right and something wrong, and both have used their rightness to avoid their blindness.

The humility this conversation requires is the willingness to admit you have gotten something wrong even in what you are getting right. The conservative needs

The biblical vision is neither progressive nor conservative. It honors the body without treating it as destiny; it affirms the design of male and female without weaponizing those categories; it makes room for the man made for tenderness, the woman made for authority, and the complexity that defies easy categorization. It treats the body as neither irrelevant nor determinative. What is required is the capacity to hold both truths without letting one collapse into the other. Your body is not destiny. Your body also matters. Your sex is not your entire identity. Your sex is not nothing. You are not free to be entirely self-created. You are not imprisoned by your creation. This conversation will not be resolved by arguments. It will be resolved by people willing to say: I have been wrong in the way I have applied this truth; I have let my rightness become an excuse for someone else's pain. What does faithfulness look like that honors both the design and the dignity, both the given and the chosen? Until both sides

CHAPTER 6

CHILDREN, PUBERTY BLOCKERS, AND THE CHURCH'S RESPONSIBILITY

*What every Christian parent needs to know about
gender-questioning youth, puberty blockers, and
slowing down*

A thirteen-year-old assigned female at birth starts talking about being a boy, and the parents are confused; they do not know if this is a phase, whether their child is experiencing dysphoria, or whether something else is happening. They search online and find two camps waiting for them: one insisting that immediate transition is necessary and that waiting causes trauma, the other insisting it is a phase and that to affirm anything is to harm your child.

So the parents are paralyzed. They do not know what to do. They know their child is struggling, but they do not know whether the struggle is dysphoria or something else entirely—trauma, peer influence, depression, or body dysphoria, the hatred of one's body, which is a different thing from dysphoria, the experience of one's gender as misaligned. The church has largely failed these families. We have either said, "This is a sin, pray away the confusion," or we have said, "Affirm your child's gender identity, and if you do not, you are a bigot." Neither serves the family. This chapter is for those parents, and for the churches trying to help them.

THE RISE OF GENDER-QUESTIONING YOUTH

First, a fact that is not debated: the number of young people questioning their gender has risen significantly over the past decade. Surveys from 2021 through 2024 show that approximately twenty percent of Gen Z identifies as something other than cisgender and heterosexual—substantially higher than previous generations—and the rise is particularly notable among assigned females who now describe themselves as trans or non-binary. What explains this? There are several factors, and honest analysis means acknowledging all of them

Social acceptance has increased. A generation ago, a young person with questions about gender could not explore them safely; now, in many communities, there is space to ask. This is not bad—more space to think is better than no space—but it does mean more young people will explore these questions. Social contagion is also real. When a peer transitions or questions gender, it influences other peers, and this is not unique to gender; when one friend gets piercings, others often follow, and when one friend struggles with depression, the concept becomes more visible to the rest. Social influence is part of how young people develop identity, and gender questions are no exception.

Online communities and social media accelerate all of this. A young person can now find community online around gender identity questions in ways they could not before, which creates both opportunity and risk—the opportunity to find people with similar questions, and the risk of being driven toward particular conclusions by algorithms and community pressure. Mental health is connected too. Many young people questioning gender also experience depression, anxiety, autism, or trauma; the relationship between these is complex, but honest analysis means acknowledging that gender questioning sometimes co-occurs with other struggles.

And the ideological environment has shifted. Gender ideology has become mainstream in schools, libraries, and some churches, and this is not neutral; it shapes how young people interpret their own experience. A young person who a decade ago might have experienced gender

WHAT PUBERTY BLOCKERS ACTUALLY ARE

Let us be clear and specific about medical interventions. Puberty blockers are medications, typically GnRH agonists, that suppress the hormones that trigger puberty; they pause pubertal development, and they do not cause permanent changes, so that if stopped, puberty typically resumes. The medications have been used for decades in other contexts—to treat precocious puberty, the puberty that arrives too early, and, off-label, for gender dysphoria.

What do they do? They pause pubertal development and prevent the development of secondary sex characteristics—breast development, testicular development, voice changes, body hair. They prevent menstruation. They prevent the height growth spurt that typically happens in puberty. The claimed benefit is time for exploration: a young person questioning their gender can take time without their body changing in ways they find dysphoric, which buys time for therapy, for thinking, for determining what is really happening.

The risks are not fully understood. Puberty blockers have not been used for gender dysphoria for decades, so we do not have long-term outcome data; we know they can

Parents are often told, "Puberty blockers are reversible. You can always stop them and puberty will resume." This is technically true. But puberty that resumes at sixteen after being paused at thirteen is not the same as puberty that happens at thirteen. Development happens in windows, and disrupting those windows has effects. A Christian parent has to understand what puberty blockers actually are before deciding whether to pursue them.

THE DETransition QUESTION: WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

One thing the affirming side of this debate rarely raises is detransition. Some young people transition socially or medically and then later detransition; the numbers vary by study, with some research suggesting that one to eight percent of those who transition socially detransition, and higher figures for medical transition regret, where some research suggests that eight to forty percent of young people on puberty blockers or hormones later regret it or stop treatment.

Why? The reasons vary. Some realized their dysphoria was related to trauma or abuse; some realized it was tied

The church's job is not to forbid transition. The church's job is to help families think carefully—to ensure that medical decisions are made with actual informed consent, not ideology-driven consent where one option is constantly affirmed and the others are dismissed as bigotry.

WHAT CHILDREN ACTUALLY NEED

Here is what a child or adolescent questioning their gender actually needs. First, they need safety: they need to know that questioning their gender will not result in rejection, ridicule, or loss of love, because a young person who hides their feelings for fear of a parent's response will not get help—they will seek it elsewhere, in online communities that may be ideologically driven. Second, they need time. Not time to transition, but time to explore, to think, to talk to trusted adults, to understand what they are experiencing. Gender questioning in early adolescence often resolves by adulthood, and pushing toward quick conclusions works against time doing its work.

Fifth, they need community—not an online community of gender-affirming ideology, but actual relationship with adults who love them, who can help them think, who can walk with them through confusion. The church should be that community. And sixth, they need you to let them be confused. The pressure in current culture is to have an answer—either "you are definitely trans and you need to transition" or "you are confused and it will pass"—and young people are told they must know who they are, what their gender is, what to call themselves. This is unfair. Adolescence is a time of exploration. Let them explore. Let them ask questions without forcing them to choose.

WHAT THE CHURCH SHOULD TELL PARENTS

If a Christian parent comes to you and says, "My child is questioning their gender; what do I do?" begin here: first, you love your child—that is the foundation, and nothing

Then, third, seek good therapy—not affirmative therapy that assumes your child is trans and needs to transition, but exploratory therapy that helps your child understand what they are experiencing. Is it dysphoria? Is it trauma? Is it depression? Is it peer influence? A good therapist asks these questions. Then, fourth, get information; read from sources that are not ideologically driven, understand what medical interventions actually are, understand the risks, and understand what reversible and irreversible mean.

Then, fifth, create safety. Your child needs to know they can talk to you, that questioning their gender will not result in rejection—but also that you will tell them the truth, even when the truth is uncomfortable. Then, sixth, hold your convictions. You believe sexual difference is real and created by God; you believe the body matters; you believe gender ideology is not the answer. Hold those convictions clearly and lovingly, because your child needs to know what you actually believe, not just what you think they want to hear. And then, seventh, do not abandon your child into ideology on either side. Do not say, "Go figure this out with your peers or your online community," and do not say, "I wash my hands of this." Stay involved. Stay loving. Stay engaged. Your child needs you.

THE MEDICAL ESTABLISHMENT'S CAUTION

This is worth noting clearly: even the medical establishment is increasingly cautious about rapid

This does not mean transition is never appropriate. It means the medical establishment itself is saying: slow down, think carefully, do not assume medical transition is the answer, and ensure young people have psychological support and time to think before medical decisions are made. The church should echo this caution—not as a political statement, but as a pastoral one. We care about young people, and young people deserve careful, thoughtful, non-ideological medical care.

RAPID ONSET GENDER DYSPHORIA AND SOCIAL CONTAGION

Over the past ten years, clinicians began noticing something unusual: a significant number of adolescents, particularly assigned females, were reporting gender dysphoria for the first time without any prior history of gender nonconformity. The pattern was a young person who had shown no dysphoria in childhood suddenly reporting it and requesting transition in early adolescence, often after their peer group had affirmed the identity. Some clinicians described this as "Rapid Onset

The research on ROGD is contested. Some studies support the reality of the pattern; others suggest the data is more complex. But honest analysis requires acknowledging that some young people experience dysphoria that correlates with peer group influence. This does not mean all gender dysphoria is socially influenced, and it does not mean social contagion is the only explanation. It means social contagion is one factor among several.

Consider what the social environment now does that would not have existed ten years ago. Social media algorithms: if a young person expresses any uncertainty about gender, the algorithm will show them content from trans communities, trans creators, and trans ideology, building a feed that affirms one particular conclusion. Online communities: a young person can find community around being transgender, communities that can be genuinely supportive but can also push toward particular conclusions. School policies: many schools now allow students to use preferred names and pronouns without parental notification, so the school environment actively affirms gender identity exploration. And peer effects: when one peer transitions, other peers explore their own gender—not a new thing, since adolescents have always influenced one another, but the speed and intensity of that influence is amplified by social media.

A parent needs to understand that when an adolescent comes out as transgender, it is not enough to ask, "Is this

THE PARENTAL DILEMMA: DECIDING WITHOUT CERTAINTY

A parent whose child is expressing gender dysphoria faces an impossible situation, because whatever decision the parent makes—whether to support social transition, whether to consider medical intervention, whether to seek a particular kind of therapy—could be wrong. The parent cannot get certainty. The science is incomplete, the theology is contested, and the child's future is unknowable. Yet the parent has to decide, because the child cannot wait while the parent achieves a certainty that will never come.

What should the parent do? First, slow down: you do not have to decide immediately, and you do not have to choose a path in response to cultural pressure from either side—take time, think carefully, get information. Second, seek good professionals: a therapist who will help your child understand their experience rather than quickly

Fourth, remember that your child's questioning is not the same as a permanent identity; adolescence involves exploration, and gender questioning in adolescence often resolves—which does not mean your child is confused but that your child is normal, so let them explore without rushing them toward permanent decisions. Fifth, hold your convictions: you believe some things about the body and gender, so hold those convictions and teach them to your child, but do not use them as a weapon—use them as a foundation. Sixth, create safety, because your child needs to know that questioning their gender will not result in rejection or loss of love; a child who fears your response will not come to you but will go elsewhere. And seventh, be honest about uncertainty: you do not have all the answers, and the world does not either, and admitting this is not weakness but honesty.

The parent's job is not to solve this immediately. The parent's job is to love the child, to help the child think carefully, to refuse to abandon the child to ideology on either side, and to walk with the child through a genuinely confusing time. That is enough. That is not everything. But it is enough.

THE CHILD, THE ADOLESCENT, THE ADULT: THREE DIFFERENT

What the church should do when a young person experiences gender dysphoria requires three fundamentally different answers depending on age, because the developmental reality is fundamentally different. The same response that would be appropriate for a child would be harmful for an adolescent, and the same response appropriate for an adolescent would be inappropriately patronizing for an adult. The mistake churches often make is treating all three situations the same way.

Consider a child around seven who is expressing that they think they are a different gender from the one assigned at birth. This is worth taking seriously, but it calls for a different response than an adolescent's questioning or an adult's persistent dysphoria. At seven, a child is still developing a sense of self; the child's identity is not yet formed, and children at this age engage in imaginative play, question everything, and often change their minds about identity, interests, and preferences. A child might insist they are a dinosaur; a child might insist they are a different gender; both are part of how children explore and understand reality. Some children who express gender questioning later identify with their biological sex, some continue to experience dysphoria, and some express it for a period before it resolves—the pattern is not predictable.

The pastoral response to a family with a seven-year-old expressing gender dysphoria should be to slow down. This is not an emergency, and it does not require immediate social transition; this child needs psychological evaluation and support, not ideology on either side, and the family should be helped to understand what the child is

An adolescent around fourteen or fifteen requesting social transition and raising the question of hormones is developmentally different. Adolescence is a time of identity formation, and questions about gender are normal; some adolescents work through questioning and end up identifying with their biological sex, some do not, some explore for years before deciding, and some change their minds multiple times. But adolescence is also a time of significant physical change, psychological vulnerability, and peer influence. The adolescent's brain is not fully developed, particularly in areas related to long-term decision-making and impulse control—the prefrontal cortex, the part of the brain responsible for evaluating long-term consequences, is not fully mature until the mid-twenties. The adolescent's sense of identity is not yet stable, and the adolescent is uniquely susceptible to peer

The pastoral response here should be more deliberate, because this is a time for real conversation. The family should understand what the adolescent is experiencing: When did the dysphoria start? Was it gradual or sudden? Are there other adolescents in the peer group expressing similar things? Is the adolescent following content creators or online communities that normalize gender questioning? Has the adolescent experienced trauma? Is there depression or anxiety underlying the dysphoria? What does the adolescent hope will happen, and what does the adolescent fear? This requires professional psychological evaluation—not therapy designed to affirm the identity quickly, but therapy designed to help the adolescent understand themselves—and the church should encourage it, while also encouraging the family not to make permanent medical decisions before the adolescent is older.

What should this look like practically? Social transition—using chosen names and pronouns—can happen without medical intervention, allowing the adolescent to explore identity without irreversible physical changes. This is not rejection. It is wisdom, a way for the adolescent to explore at a pace that allows for genuine discernment. Medical decisions about puberty blockers or hormones should wait until the adolescent is older—ideally until mid-to-late adolescence or early adulthood—and should require thorough psychological evaluation. This is not prohibition. It is caution appropriate to the developmental stage; the adolescent's brain and identity are still developing, and it is reasonable to allow that development to occur before

An adult around eighteen or older who has experienced persistent dysphoria for years and is now requesting medical transition is in a different situation. The person has achieved legal adulthood, has had time to think through options, the dysphoria is not new, and the person has presumably had time to consider what other conditions might be playing a role. The church's response should be different too. This is less about protection from rushed decision-making, though that still matters, and more about honoring the autonomy of an adult while maintaining the church's theological convictions. The church can say: "We believe that bodies are created good by God. We believe that accepting embodied existence, rather than escaping it, is the path to peace. We believe that transformation comes not through medical fixing of the body but through grace and acceptance. We also honor your right to make decisions about your own body. We do not fully affirm this choice, but we do not reject you. We remain in relationship with you. We will call you by your chosen name. We invite you into our community. But we cannot pretend to believe what we do not believe about what it means to accept embodied existence. And we want to walk with you toward actual peace, not escape." This is harder than either complete affirmation or complete rejection. But it is the path of genuine pastoral care that

A seven-year-old needs time and evaluation and space to develop. A fifteen-year-old needs space to explore without permanent medical changes. An eighteen-year-old deserves respect for their autonomy. The pastoral response in each case should be proportionate to the actual situation. A pastor should be trained to ask: How old is this person? How long have they experienced dysphoria? What other conditions might be present? What professional evaluation have they received? What does their family think? What does the broader community look like? Are they under pressure to make decisions? Is there time to slow down? These questions are not dismissive. They are what care looks like.

APPLICATION: THE CHURCH'S ROLE

What is the church's actual responsibility here? First, be a safe community: make it clear that young people questioning gender will not be mocked, will not be rejected, will not be abandoned—this is non-negotiable. Second, teach the theology: make sure young people understand what Scripture teaches about the body, about sexual difference, about identity in Christ, and do not assume they already know it—teach it clearly and lovingly. Third, help families: offer resources, counseling, and community to families with gender-questioning young people, helping them think carefully rather than ideologically.

Fourth, refuse both failures. Do not let your church be a place where gender-questioning young people are mocked, and do not let it be a place where ideological affirmation is the only option; offer something better—

Young people questioning gender are not enemies. They are young people in confusion who deserve the church to be the safest place they can be—safe to ask questions, safe to be confused, safe to explore, safe to come to different conclusions than the culture suggests. If the church can be that place, we will win far more hearts than any other strategy.

CHAPTER 7

PRONOUNS, BATHROOMS, AND THE DAILY QUESTIONS

*Practical Christian ethics for the everyday
questions — names, pronouns, bathrooms,
schools, and workplaces*

*They are small in the scheme of
theology. They are enormous in the
scheme of someone's felt belonging.*

A coworker tells you they are transitioning and asks you to use they/them pronouns. A teacher in your church asks whether it is appropriate to use a student's chosen

These are the questions the church debates endlessly—pronouns, bathrooms, names. They seem small until they are not. Until they are the difference between feeling welcome and feeling rejected; until they are the thing that keeps someone from church; until they are the line in the sand that decides whether someone believes the church sees them as human at all.

The church has not done the work to give clear, thoughtful, non-ideological guidance on these daily questions, so people default to what they have on hand—their politics, their feelings, or the loudest voice in the room. You need something better. You need theology that tells you what to do when you actually meet these questions in real life.

THE PRONOUNS QUESTION

Let's start with the simplest and somehow most contentious: pronouns. Someone asks you to use they/them instead of she/her. What do you do?

The political right often treats pronouns as a line in the sand—"I will not do this; pronouns are biology; I will not participate in a lie." The political left treats it as a matter of basic human dignity—"If you refuse to use someone's pronouns, you are committing violence against them." Both positions miss something important.

First: pronouns are not nothing. Language matters, and

Here is what I think, pastorally and theologically. If someone asks you to use pronouns different from their biological sex, you can do it. It is not a compromise of your faith. It is not affirming gender ideology. It is treating someone with basic dignity. But you do not have to do it. Using pronouns that correspond to biological sex is not sinful, and it is not bigotry; it is one option among several.

What you cannot do, if you love the person, is mock them for asking. You cannot treat the request as an attack, and you cannot use it as an opportunity to declare your beliefs about gender. You can respectfully use their pronouns, or you can respectfully decline and offer to refer to them by name instead. But if someone is in genuine dysphoria, and using different pronouns helps them feel more at home in community, and that costs you nothing but a small linguistic shift, the gospel counsel is clear: lay down your preferences for someone else's peace.

This does not mean capitulating to ideology. It means choosing kindness when kindness costs little.

THE PRACTICAL COUNSEL ON

Here is what I suggest to churches. Create space for people to share pronouns if they want to—some trans or non-binary people want their pronouns known, and some do not, so let it be a choice rather than a requirement. Use the pronouns people ask for when you are with them; this is the same basic respect by which you call someone by the name they prefer, and it is what we do for people we love.

But do not demand it from everyone. Do not make pronoun agreement a test of faith or orthodoxy, and do not shame someone who uses pronouns that correspond to biological sex. By the same measure, do not use preferred pronouns as a way to mock someone, do not announce that you are using pronouns you do not "believe in" as a cynical performance, and do not build an us-versus-them dynamic around the whole question.

Teach people that pronouns are courtesy, not theology—a way of showing respect, not a declaration of theological truth. And teach this too: if someone cannot remember the pronouns you request, and they are genuinely trying, extend grace. Memory fails and people stumble. If someone is honestly working to honor your request and slips, that is not violence; that is human limitation. The goal is simple—to make space for people to be known, to be called by the names and pronouns that matter to them, without turning pronouns into a battlefield.

THE BATHROOM QUESTION

Then there are bathrooms. This is where theology becomes policy, and policy becomes a cultural battle. The

There is genuine tension here. Someone early in transition, whose appearance does not yet match their identity, will feel unsafe in either bathroom; the church's job is not to eliminate that discomfort—you cannot—but to minimize it and to make the space safe.

Here is what I think theologically: the body is real, biological sex is real, and some people are uncomfortable being undressed in spaces with people of a different biological sex. That discomfort is understandable. But it is not the end of the conversation. Here is what I think pastorally: if a trans person in your congregation needs to use the restroom, the church's job is to make a decision that protects their dignity and minimizes risk to others. That might mean a private restroom; it might mean signage that reads "All Stalls Have Full Privacy"; it might mean a policy that allows people to use the restroom matching their identity. It depends on your context.

What you cannot do is treat a trans person in your church as a threat. What you cannot do is make bathroom access a test of acceptance. What you cannot do is design policies that protect one group by harming another. The rule is simple—love your neighbor as yourself—and that neighbor is a trans person who needs to use the bathroom. How do you treat them with dignity while also respecting the comfort of others? That is a practical question, not an ideological one, and different churches will answer it differently; but the answer should emerge from love, not from fear or ideology.

Then there is the question of names. Someone you have known since childhood comes out as trans and asks you to use a different name. What do you do?

You use the new name. This is not complicated. You have called someone by a nickname; you have called someone by a maiden name; you have learned to call someone by the name they preferred. You can learn to call someone by their new chosen name. But—and this is important—you do not have to do it perfectly the first day, and you do not have to be ashamed if you stumble. Learning a new name takes time. If someone has been "Sarah" for thirty years and is now "James," your brain will stumble, you will accidentally reach for the old name, and you will catch yourself and correct. That is human and normal. What matters is whether you are trying, whether you are making an effort, whether you show respect for the change.

In churches this gets complicated because of how names are used—prayer lists, worship announcements, email communications, bureaucratic systems all built around names—and the church can make decisions about when and how to use the chosen name in different contexts. But when you are talking with the person directly, you use the name they prefer. This is not a political statement. This is basic respect.

WORKPLACES, SCHOOLS, AND THE HARDER QUESTIONS

These daily questions get harder in institutional contexts. An employee transitions and asks to use a

These are genuinely hard. They involve competing values, institutional policy, legal considerations, and pastoral care all at once. What I suggest is to take each situation individually rather than making grand ideological pronouncements that force a single outcome, and to work with the person involved toward a solution that respects their dignity while also respecting the institution's values and the other people affected.

In a church context you have more freedom to be explicitly Christian. You can say: "We believe biblical truth about gender. And we also believe you are made in God's image, and we will treat you with respect." That is clear, and it is both true. In a secular workplace the same principle applies in different language: "We respect your identity and we will use the name and pronouns you prefer. We also have policies about bathrooms and privacy that apply to everyone." The point is that you do not have to choose between ideology on one side and complete capitulation on the other. You can hold your values and treat people with respect.

Here is what I tell people when they are actually in the room with someone who is trans or questioning. First, listen more than you speak—listen to their story, their suffering, the reasons this matters to them, and do not assume you already understand. Second, ask genuine questions; not rhetorical ones designed to trap them, but real ones: "Tell me your story. How long have you felt this way? What does it mean to you to be called by this name? What made you decide to transition?"

Third, honor what you can without compromising what you cannot. You may not agree with gender ideology, but you can use someone's preferred name; you may not believe in transition, but you can respect the person in front of you; you may not affirm their choices, but you can affirm their humanity. Fourth, do not perform your convictions. Do not use the conversation as an occasion to declare what you believe about gender, and do not make it about you. Make it about them. Later, in appropriate contexts, you can share your views—but when you are with them, the conversation is about understanding them, not educating them.

Fifth, love them as they are. Not after they repent, not after they change their mind, not after they come back to biological reality—right now, as they are. This is what the gospel teaches. God loves us while we are still sinners, and the church should love people while they are in whatever situation they are in. Sixth, do not abandon them. This is where the church has failed most dramatically; trans people have been abandoned by churches, cast out, condemned, mocked. The church should be the opposite—the place that does not abandon you no matter how

THE LIMITS OF THIS COUNSEL

I want to be clear about what I am not saying. I am not saying: affirm every choice. Medical transition is not something the church should simply affirm as obvious and good; the church should help people think carefully about the costs and consequences. I am not saying: the church has no wisdom about the body and gender and identity. We do. A biblical theology of the body, of sexual difference, of what it means to be image-bearers—this matters, and we should teach it. I am not saying: there are no policies to set or decisions to make. Churches and institutions have to make real decisions about bathrooms, names, and policies, and those decisions should be made thoughtfully, not ideologically.

What I am saying is that the basic posture toward the person in front of you should be respect, not suspicion; love, not judgment; "how can we serve you in this community" rather than "how do we protect ourselves from you." The daily questions—pronouns, bathrooms, names—are the things that decide whether someone feels welcome. They are small in the scheme of theology. They are enormous in the scheme of someone's felt belonging. The church's job is to get them right. Not politically right. Pastorally right—in a way that honors both truth and the person in front of you.

TITLE IX, BOSTOCK, AND THE LEGAL

The church does not exist in a vacuum. Christians work in places governed by law. A Christian employer has to understand employment law; a Christian teacher in a public school has to understand Title IX; a Christian healthcare provider has to understand healthcare law as it applies to gender.

In 2020, the Supreme Court ruled in *Bostock v. Clayton County* that the prohibition on sex discrimination in Title VII of the Civil Rights Act of 1964 includes discrimination on the basis of sexual orientation and gender identity. What does that mean practically? It means a Christian employer cannot legally fire someone for being transgender; it means a Christian-owned business cannot legally refuse service based on transgender status; it means many of the positions Christians want to take on gender have become legally impossible. This creates real tension. A Christian believes certain things about gender and the body, and a Christian also has to operate within the law.

How should a Christian handle this? First, by understanding what the law actually says. *Bostock* covers employment discrimination and, in some contexts, public accommodations; it does not require affirmation of ideology, but it does require treating people with legal equality. Second, by distinguishing what the law requires from what the gospel requires; the law might require that you use someone's preferred name in an employment context, while the gospel requires that you treat that person with love and respect—not the same thing, but able to coexist.

A Christian in HR has to learn the law so as not to discriminate inadvertently while still holding personal convictions. A Christian teacher has to handle curriculum requirements while maintaining a theology. A Christian healthcare provider has to work within medical law while thinking carefully about ethical boundaries. The church should prepare Christians for this—not by telling them to ignore the law, but by helping them understand it and think carefully about how to handle it with integrity. Most churches have not done this work, and the result is that Christians in professional contexts are left to figure it out alone.

PRACTICAL CHURCH POLICY: NAMES, BATHROOMS, SPORTS, CAMPS

The harm done to transgender people can be named in the abstract, but what does repentance look like in concrete policy decisions? A church has to decide how it will actually handle these questions in real time. Policy is not the same as theology, but policy flows from theology and creates the lived experience that shapes how people encounter the gospel.

A young person in dysphoria already knows they feel misaligned with the gender they were assigned. Every time someone uses their birth name, it reinforces the misalignment; every time someone uses their chosen name, it is an act of respect that says, "I see you." So the policy should be a name change in your records, with counselors, youth leaders, and volunteers informed and expected to use the chosen name. If someone slips occasionally, that is human; if it becomes a pattern, that is a problem and should be addressed. The message the church sends is clear: we see you and we honor your name. This does not require theological affirmation. It requires basic respect.

Pronouns are more complex. A young person requests they/them, and your church should ask whether it can accommodate this. Many can. Many leaders will find they/them unfamiliar, but learning is not impossible, and the policy should allow for accommodation while recognizing that some people genuinely struggle with it. What matters is the spirit of the decision. If your church uses preferred

The argument that "they/them is not grammatically correct" is a bad argument. English is a living language, and language changes. Singular they has been used in English since the fourteenth century; "If someone comes to the door, ask them to wait" uses singular they and sounds correct to any native speaker. If you can learn to say "you all" in the South, you can learn "they" as singular—and if you refuse, it communicates rejection, not theological principle. Your policy might be that preferred pronouns are used in private pastoral settings, in communications to the young person, and in settings where they create no conflict, while in public settings the church uses respectful language that honors the person without necessarily using pronouns they object to. That is a reasonable middle ground. What your policy should not do is use pronoun refusal as a form of ideological resistance.

Bathrooms require more complexity because there is a genuine practical issue. Single-stall bathrooms solve most of the problem; if your youth center has individual bathrooms, there is no conflict, because young people who are not socially transitioned use the bathroom matching their biological sex and everyone keeps privacy and dignity. If you do not have single-stall bathrooms, you have to think carefully. Your policy might be that young people who are not yet medically transitioned use the bathroom matching their biological sex, while young people on hormone therapy may request the bathroom matching

Sports and camps require similar thought. A young person who was assigned male at birth but identifies as female requests to continue playing on the girls' soccer team after social transition; your decision depends on whether your league rules allow it. If your league follows state high school athletic association rules, check them, because they are evolving; if your church organizes the league, you get to decide. A reasonable policy might be that for recreational leagues, where physical differences do not significantly affect fairness or safety, you prioritize inclusion, and for competitive leagues, where significant physical differences create fairness issues, you follow biological sex. That is not rejection; it is a recognition that different contexts carry different considerations. At camps, the issue is usually sleeping arrangements and bathroom facilities, and a reasonable policy might be that young people sleep in cabins based on the gender they identify with unless there is a significant safety concern, with all sleeping areas supervised appropriately and all bathroom facilities offering privacy. The goal is dignity and safety for everyone.

What matters in all of this is that your church is not driven primarily by ideology of any kind. You are driven by the question: how do we love people, treat them with dignity, and help them belong? That requires policy—but

The deeper question is this: how do we hold conviction about what we believe regarding embodiment while also making room for people whose embodied experience is confused and painful? This is the tension every Christian community faces. One church solves it by abandoning conviction—it affirms everything because it fears that rejection is cruelty, and it offers belonging but no truth; a young person can be part of that community, but they are not being helped, only left alone in their confusion. Another church solves it by abandoning compassion—it holds clear doctrine but refuses to build bridges to people living differently, so a young person in dysphoria is not welcome, or is welcome only on condition of agreeing with the church's theology, which is not welcome at all but coercion.

A third way exists. Your church can say: We believe something. We hold it carefully. We know what Scripture teaches. But we are bigger than our agreement on this one issue. You can be part of our community while you are wrestling. You can disagree with us and still belong. We will use your name. We will treat you with respect. We will help you think. We will walk with you. This requires training, clarity, and leadership unified in conviction and in compassion at once; it requires small groups where people do not have to pretend, pastoral staff equipped for complex conversations, and a congregation that sees disagreement as normal rather than as failure. It is not easy. Churches that do this will face criticism from both sides—progressive advocates will say you are not affirming

Policy matters because it shapes daily experience. A policy to honor chosen names shapes how a young person is treated every week they come to church; a policy on pronouns shapes whether that young person feels respected or rejected; a policy on bathrooms shapes whether they feel safe in your building; a policy on sports shapes whether they can take part in youth group activities. These are not abstract theological questions. They are practical decisions that say to a young person: you matter, you belong, we see you. That is what the church should offer. Not ideology. Not dismissal. Belonging with honesty.

CHAPTER 8

HOW THE CHURCH HAS HARMED TRANSGENDER PEOPLE

*Confession and repentance — the mockery, the
refusal, and the abandonment the church must
name*

There is a moment that repeats itself in every church that takes gender seriously. A young person, usually assigned female at birth, is sitting in the youth group or the worship service, listening to a sermon about God's design — about how God made male and female, about how that design is perfect, about how anyone who questions it is rejecting God. And as they listen, a single calculation forms: if I tell anyone who I am, I will be rejected by this community; if I admit I am struggling with my gender, I will become the sermon illustration, the cautionary tale, the evidence of what happens when you reject God's design.

This is how the church has harmed transgender people.

Not with policy. Not with doctrine. With something more insidious — the casual dismissal of their existence, the mockery disguised as conviction, the refusal to see them as people rather than as problems to be solved or positions to be condemned. The church has to confess this, not because confession is comfortable, but because confession is the only path to repentance, and repentance is the only path forward.

THE MOCKERY

Start with the simplest harm: the mockery. In some churches, transgender people are punching bags — punchlines in sermons, evidence of cultural decay, examples of what happens when people rebel against God's design. A pastor makes a joke about someone's chosen name and the congregation laughs; a youth leader refers to "these people confused about their gender," and the young people hear the message exactly as it was sent: your confusion is not legitimate, it is ridiculous, it is the

When you are the young person in the room whose confusion is being mocked, the meaning is unmistakable — you do not belong here, your experience is not taken seriously, your suffering is a joke. The suicide rates among transgender youth tell you what this does; while there are many factors, one of them is clear, because the experience of rejection and mockery in faith communities contributes to despair. The church did this. The church mocked people in genuine dysphoria and turned their suffering into a cautionary tale. This has to be confessed — not as ancient history, but as current reality.

THE REFUSAL TO LEARN

Then there is the refusal to learn. A young person comes out as trans and gives you a new name, and you ignore it; you "accidentally" use the old name, you use the old pronouns, you make clear through persistent refusal that you do not accept this person's reality. This is different from stumbling, different from the ordinary difficulty of learning a new name — this is strategic refusal, a way of saying: I do not accept you, I do not see you as you are, I will not call you by the name you have given yourself.

To someone experiencing dysphoria, to someone who has risked so much to tell you who they are, this is devastating. It is one thing to believe they are wrong; it is another to refuse to honor the name they have chosen. It is one thing to disagree about transition; it is another to name them as if their name is irrelevant. The church has done this routinely — and then wondered why trans people leave.

The specifics matter, because the question of what it

Sometimes slips are genuine. Memory fails. But if the slip happens repeatedly, if it happens more when the person is not in the room, if it comes from people who seem to be deliberately using the old name, that is not failure. That is refusal, and the person feels it. The refusal communicates something specific: "I see you as someone confused about their identity, not someone who has made a clear choice about who they are. I do not fully honor that choice." Is that always accurate? Not necessarily. But it is how the person experiences it, and the experience is real.

The same is true with pronouns. A youth leader says, "I just do not feel comfortable using they/them pronouns because I do not think they are grammatically correct," and what the young person hears is: "Your identity is grammatically incorrect. Your existence does not fit the rules I understand. Therefore I do not have to honor your request." The leader probably did not intend this. But the message is received.

The church's refusal to learn has been one of its most damaging failures — not because using someone's name is the same as affirming an ideology, but because the refusal communicates something the church should never communicate: "You are not worth the small effort it takes for me to learn your name." For the young person in

THE ABANDONMENT

The deepest harm, though, comes from abandonment. A young person in the church is struggling with dysphoria, does not know who to talk to, fears rejection, and eventually comes out to their small group — and the response is one of two things. Either, "You are sinning and you need to repent," with no offer of support, or, "We affirm you completely," which sounds like welcome but is actually ideological affirmation without any genuine relationship.

What they needed was something else entirely: "We love you. We are confused about this, but we are not going anywhere. Tell us what you need. We want to walk with you." Instead they got judgment or empty affirmation, and either way they got abandonment. The judgment was clear abandonment. But the affirmation was abandonment too, because it was ideological rather than relational — it said, "We affirm your gender identity," not, "We know you, we love you, we are here."

The young person, feeling they have no real community in the church, seeks community elsewhere — in online spaces, in gender-affirming communities, in ideology.

THE SILENCE WHEN THEY DIED

The most devastating failure is this: young people died. Transgender youth with elevated suicide rates; young people in the church who experienced dysphoria and in the end took their own lives. And the church, by and large, said nothing — nothing at the funeral, nothing from the pulpit, nothing about how it might have failed them, nothing about what should be done differently.

When the young person was alive, the church had no space for their confusion. When they died, the church had no space for the grief over what was lost and how we failed them. This is perhaps the most damning failure — not just that we were unkind, but that we were so unkind we drove some people to the edge, and then we had nothing to say about it.

WHAT REPENTANCE ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE

So what does the church do now? Repentance means more than saying "sorry." It means changing direction. It means concrete actions that show the church is different.

First, it means acknowledging the harm — not defensively explaining that we meant well, not hedging by

Third, it means training leaders differently — teaching pastors and youth leaders about gender dysphoria, teaching them how to listen without immediately trying to fix or affirm, teaching them that the first job is to understand, not to judge. Fourth, it means teaching a theology of the body: teach what Scripture says about sexual difference, about embodiment, about identity in Christ, clearly and without apology, but in a way that still makes space for people struggling with these questions. Fifth, it means changing the tone — removing mockery from sermons, removing the casual dismissal of people questioning gender, speaking about this issue with the seriousness it deserves and the compassion it requires.

Sixth, it means supporting families: when a family has a young person questioning gender, the church should show up, offering counseling and prayer and community, not to push toward a particular conclusion but to walk with them across genuinely hard terrain. Seventh, it means prayer — actual intercession for young people in dysphoria, actual grief over those we failed, actual turning to God to say: we got this wrong, help us do better.

The church stands at a crossroads on this issue. One path is to double down on mockery and dismissal — to make gender a line in the sand, to treat anyone questioning gender as someone to be defeated ideologically rather than accompanied pastorally. That path will keep driving people away, keep pushing young people in dysphoria toward ideology rather than toward faith communities, and keep building walls between the church and a generation already leaving in large numbers.

The other path is repentance and change: to confess how we have failed, to acknowledge the real harm we have done, to create genuine space for people in confusion, to teach our theology clearly while walking alongside people in pain, to refuse both cruelty and ideology. This path is harder. It requires saying, "We were wrong. We have some things to learn. We still believe some things about the body and gender, but we are going to hold those convictions alongside genuine love for people who are struggling." The gospel requires the second path — not because it is easier, but because it is true.

This issue, specific as it is, points to something larger about the American church. We have largely lost the ability to hold conviction and compassion simultaneously. We believe we have to choose: either we mock people to show we have convictions, or we abandon convictions to show compassion. We cannot do both at once — or so we think.

But Jesus did it. Jesus held uncompromised truth and genuine love for people at the same time. To the woman caught in adultery he said both "I do not condemn you" and "Go and sin no more" — both true, both spoken to the

PROPHETIC WITNESS AND PASTORAL PRESENCE: HOLDING BOTH

There is a harder tension underneath all of this, one the confession alone does not resolve: how does the church maintain prophetic witness while also being pastorally present? If the church teaches that sexual difference is real and created by God, and that the gospel calls people to accept their embodied existence, is that position already rejecting transgender people? Some would say yes — that any theology questioning the affirmation of transgender identity is inherently harmful.

But consider the comparisons. Is a church teaching that singleness is a valid calling inherently rejecting toward people who are single? Is a church teaching that children are a blessing inherently rejecting toward people who are infertile? Is a church teaching that marriage is between a man and a woman inherently rejecting toward people experiencing same-sex attraction? These are genuinely difficult questions. A church can hold convictions without being cruel about them; it can teach something and also create space for people living with the

The church's job is to do both at once — to teach what Scripture says about the body and sexual difference clearly, without apology, and also to create a context where someone dealing with dysphoria can come and know: you are welcome here, you will be heard, you will not be mocked, we will help you think. This is hard because it requires holding tension; it requires saying, "I believe sexual difference is created by God. I also believe you are made in God's image and I will treat you with respect. I do not fully understand what you are experiencing. I want to understand. Help me."

Most churches cannot hold this tension. They collapse into one side or the other, becoming either a place of prophetic witness that fails pastorally or a place of pastoral warmth that fails prophetically. The church needs to learn to hold both. That is the work.

THE CALL TO REPENTANCE

So I am calling the church to repentance. Not repentance from believing what Scripture teaches about the body and sexual difference, not repentance from holding biblical convictions — but repentance from cruelty, from mockery, from abandonment, from the refusal to see people as people rather than as problems to be solved.

Repentance means this: the next young person who walks into your church struggling with dysphoria will experience something different. Will experience a community that says, "We do not have all the answers. We believe some things about the body and gender. But you belong here. We love you. We will walk with you." That

CHAPTER 9

Intersex Conditions and the Binary Question

*What biology teaches about the limits of
categories — and why intersex is not the same as
transgender.*

*Intersex conditions do not prove the
binary is a construct. They prove the
binary has exceptions. Two different
things.*

**WHAT ARE INTERSEX CONDITIONS
(DIFFERENCES OF SEX DEVELOPMENT)?**

Intersex conditions, also called Differences of Sex Development (DSD), are variations in reproductive anatomy, chromosomes, or hormones that do not fit the typical pattern of male or female development. Androgen Insensitivity Syndrome (AIS) describes a person with XY chromosomes born with insensitivity to testosterone, so that the body develops along female lines despite male chromosomes; such a person typically has female external genitalia but different internal anatomy, and is often assigned female at birth and raised as a girl. In 5-Alpha Reductase Deficiency, a genetic condition affects how testosterone is processed, so that a baby may be assigned female because the genitalia appear female, only for testosterone production to increase at puberty and the body to develop male secondary sex characteristics.

Klinefelter Syndrome describes a person with XXY chromosomes who typically has male anatomy but may show some female physical characteristics. Turner Syndrome describes a person with a single X chromosome instead of two, who typically has female anatomy and is raised as a girl, though development often differs from the typical female pattern. In Congenital Adrenal Hyperplasia,

HOW COMMON ARE THEY?

The numbers are debated, but various estimates suggest that somewhere between 0.5% and 1.7% of people have some form of intersex condition or ambiguous genitalia. To put that in perspective, if 1% of the population is intersex, then in a congregation of 500 people roughly 5 have some intersex condition — likely without anyone knowing about it. These are not rare edge cases. These are real people in your church, your neighborhood, your world.

DO INTERSEX CONDITIONS DISPROVE THE GENDER BINARY?

This is where the conversation gets complicated. Some have argued that intersex conditions prove the gender binary is a social construct: if biology is not always binary, the argument runs, then the binary is false, gender is a spectrum, and sex is fluid. That argument misunderstands both biology and logic. Intersex conditions do not prove

Consider another binary: day and night. Day is defined by the presence of the sun, night by its absence, and it is a fairly clear binary. But what happens at dawn, or dusk, when the light shifts gradually from one to the other? Are dawn and dusk proof that the day/night binary is false? No — they are exceptions that prove the pattern is real but not absolute. In the same way, intersex conditions prove that the male/female binary is real but not absolute. Most people are clearly male or clearly female, and the biological patterns are real; but some people develop outside the typical pattern. The exception does not invalidate the pattern. It shows the pattern has limits.

WHAT BIOLOGY ACTUALLY TEACHES

Honest biology says several things at once. First, sexual difference is real: the pattern of male and female exists, and chromosomes, hormones, and anatomy typically determine it. Second, development sometimes does not follow the pattern, because for complex biological reasons it occasionally goes differently, producing a person whose sex characteristics are not typical. Third, in those cases doctors and families have to make genuinely hard decisions about sex assignment, medical care, and how to raise the child — and there is not always a clear correct answer.

Fourth, and most often missed, intersex conditions say nothing about gender identity. A person with AIS, assigned female at birth, with female external genitalia, raised as a girl and identifying as female, is not transgender; she has an intersex condition, and these are different things. The

The specifics make this plain, because understanding them reveals just how complex sexual development actually is. A person with Klinefelter Syndrome (XXY) is most often assigned male at birth, raised as a boy, and identifies as male; he has male anatomy but may have reduced testosterone production, less body hair, wider hips, or other variations, and is typically infertile. How does such a person relate to his body? Like everyone else — it is his actual body, the one he lives in — though it may not match what he expected after being told he is male. He may feel confusion, but most do not experience dysphoria; he may feel difference, but difference is not the same as wrongness. Many people with Klinefelter never receive a diagnosis at all, because their expression of masculinity seems unremarkable, and they go through life not knowing about the extra chromosome.

A person with Turner Syndrome (45,X — a single X chromosome) is typically assigned female at birth, raised as a girl, and identifies as female, while living with short stature, possible cardiac or kidney differences, a particular physical presentation, and frequent infertility. Like Klinefelter individuals, Turner individuals are typically not transgender; they are assigned female, identify as female, and simply developed differently than the typical pattern. The question for the church is how to help someone

Congenital Adrenal Hyperplasia (CAH) describes a person with XX chromosomes who, because of a heritable adrenal condition, experiences higher testosterone exposure in utero, producing presentations from mild to severe; the external genitalia may appear more male than female, or ambiguous, so that a child might be assigned male or female depending on appearance. Some CAH individuals grow up with confusion about their sex because the assignment does not match what they expected — some assigned female grow up thinking they are male, some assigned male identify as female. The point is that these are not cases of gender identity diverging from biological sex in the way we describe transgender identity; they are cases of sexual development that did not follow the typical pattern, leading to confusion about sex itself, not merely about gender identity.

Complete Androgen Insensitivity Syndrome (CAIS) describes a person with XY chromosomes who is wholly insensitive to testosterone, so the body cannot respond to the hormone; she develops typically female anatomy and typically identifies as female despite being chromosomally XY, and many people with CAIS do not discover the condition until they fail to menstruate and seek evaluation. Partial Androgen Insensitivity Syndrome (PAIS) is similar but with some sensitivity, producing a range of characteristics that may not fit typical patterns, mixing some typical male and some typical female traits, with almost infinite variation. In 5-alpha-reductase

What do these conditions teach? Sexual difference is not determined by any single factor. Chromosomes, hormone exposure, hormone receptivity, anatomy, neurology — all of these can vary independently. A person can be chromosomally one sex and have physical characteristics typical of another; a person can be genetically male but have complete female development, or genetically female but have experienced extensive male-typical hormone exposure. Seen this way, the merism of Genesis 1:27 — male and female — starts to look less metaphorical and more literally biological.

INTERSEX IS NOT THE SAME AS TRANSGENDER

So what does this teach us theologically? The binary is real. Genesis 1:27 stands; God created humanity male and female, and this is the pattern, the way human reproduction works, a fundamental reality. But the pattern has limits, because the created world is sometimes more complex than the pattern. This is what it means to live in a

This differs from the gender-ideology position, which says intersex conditions prove the binary is false, therefore gender identity is more real than biological sex, therefore one should transition if that matches one's identity. But it also differs from the rigid position, which says the binary is absolute and admits no exceptions, so that if intersex conditions exist we will pretend they do not, or force them into the binary anyway. The Christian position is more humble: the pattern is real, the exceptions are real, we do not fully understand why exceptions exist, and we respond with wisdom, compassion, and honesty.

If intersex people are in your church — and they likely are — several things follow. First, intersex is not the same as transgender; intersex people may or may not be transgender, but most are not questioning their gender at all. They were assigned a sex at birth, raised as that sex, and identify as that sex; they simply happen to have a medical condition. Some intersex people are transgender, but that is a separate matter. Second, medical decisions are genuinely hard. Many intersex people had surgeries as infants to normalize their genitalia, and some of those decisions, made by doctors and parents, have been controversial — some are grateful for them, some regret

Third, intersex conditions can affect identity, but in complex ways. Someone assigned female at birth with AIS will experience her body differently than a typical female, and that difference may create confusion — but it does not necessarily create dysphoria. It may simply be: my body is different than I thought it was. Fourth, it means inclusion. Intersex people have often been invisible in church conversations, not welcomed to talk about their condition, not included in discussions about gender and the body. The church should create space where intersex people can be known, can talk about their conditions, and can explore what it means to be intersex and how that shapes their faith.

This is also why a chapter on intersex belongs in a book about transgender identity: because intersex conditions complicate the conversation in ways both sides need to face. If you believe gender is absolutely binary and admits no exceptions, you have to reckon with intersex conditions, which exist, are real, and do not fit neatly. If you believe gender is fluid and identity is primary, you have to reckon with the fact that intersex conditions exist yet many intersex people have no gender dysphoria and do not question their gender — most identify with the sex they were assigned at birth. Even if gender were completely fluid, intersex conditions would not prove it. Intersex conditions teach both sides humility.

Much about intersex development we do not fully understand, and that matters. Why do these conditions

I want to be clear, again, about the limit of the analogy: while intersex conditions are relevant to conversations about gender, they do not settle the transgender question. Intersex people have biological reasons for their sex being atypical, whereas transgender people typically have typical biological sex but experience their gender differently. These are not identical situations. Using intersex people as evidence for gender ideology turns their existence into a prop for a political argument, and intersex people deserve better than that. But ignoring intersex people because they do not fit neatly into either camp is also wrong. The church should include intersex people, understand intersex conditions, recognize that biology is sometimes more complex than our categories, and hold the complexity without collapsing the distinctions.

WHAT THE INTERSEX MEDICAL HISTORY TEACHES THE CHURCH

There is a pastoral dimension to all of this that the

The church learned nothing from this. And now it watches the conversation shift to transgender youth without seeing the parallel: a young person expressing dysphoria, adults making decisions about medical intervention based on assumptions about identity, irreversible physical changes. The church should learn from the intersex history — be very cautious about medical intervention on young people's bodies, be willing to honor what a person's sense of self tells them, be willing to acknowledge that some people have genuinely unusual embodied experiences. But do not assume that medical intervention is always the answer, and ensure thorough evaluation before permanent changes.

The intersex person harmed by unnecessary surgery did not need the body changed. They needed help understanding their unusual body and accepting it; they needed community that did not shame them for embodied

What the intersex advocate is saying that the church needs to hear comes down to this: do not make decisions about people's bodies without their consent and without thorough understanding of what is really happening; do not assume that medical intervention is always the answer; do not treat embodied variation as a problem that needs to be fixed. The same counsel applies to churches thinking about transgender people. Do not rush. Do not assume. Do not treat every question as though there were only one right answer. The intersex person and the transgender person have this in common: bodies that do not fit the typical pattern. The church's job is not to fix that. The church's job is to help them find peace with what is.

For some, that peace will include medical intervention. For others, it will mean accepting what is and finding meaning beyond fixing the body. Either way, the path to

CHAPTER 10

TRANSGENDER PEOPLE IN YOUR CHURCH

Membership, baptism, leadership, and belonging
— *practical answers for the questions churches*
avoid

The moment comes in every church eventually. A person in transition starts attending, or someone already in the pews comes out as transgender, and suddenly the church has to answer practical questions it has spent years avoiding. Can they be baptized? Should they be? Do we require some kind of repentance first—and repentance from what? What do we do about leadership; can they teach, can they lead worship; what about membership? Different churches answer these questions differently, and the answers reveal what a church actually believes about gender, about grace, and about what it means to belong to God's people.

THE FUNDAMENTAL QUESTION: MEMBERSHIP IN THE BODY OF CHRIST

Before we answer the specific questions, we have to answer the foundational one: is a transgender person a legitimate member of the body of Christ? The gospel answer is yes. A transgender person is made in God's image, can believe in Jesus, can repent of sin and trust Christ, can be baptized and united to His body. This is not complicated theologically. A person's gender identity or gender confusion does not disqualify them from the gospel; sexual confusion is not the unforgivable sin, and dysphoria is not a barrier to grace. If a transgender person comes to faith in Christ, confesses Jesus as Lord, and wants to be baptized, the church's response should be baptism.

None of that means the church has no other wisdom to offer. It does not mean the church should refuse to help someone think carefully about medical transition or identity questions, and it does not mean the church should simply affirm all choices without reflection. But it does mean one thing without exception: do not use transition as a barrier to belonging to God's people.

That growth might look different than the person expects. It might involve learning to be at peace in the body they have rather than the body they wish they had; it might involve discovering that their identity runs deeper than their gender; and it might involve learning that the gospel offers resources for peace and transformation that ideology cannot. Membership means we are going to walk together. We are not perfect. You are not perfect. But we are committed to following Jesus together. That is hospitality. That is what the church should offer.

BAPTISM: THE PUBLIC COMMITMENT

Should a transgender person be baptized? The only legitimate reason to withhold baptism from anyone is that they have not come to faith in Christ. Baptism is the public declaration of faith in Jesus; if someone has believed, they should be baptized. A transgender person's gender identity is not a barrier to baptism, their confusion is not a barrier, their dysphoria is not a barrier. If they have believed in Jesus, they should be baptized.

LEADERSHIP AND THE HARDER QUESTION

Then there is leadership. Can a transgender person be a pastor, teach, lead worship? This is where churches have to think carefully. On one level it is the same as any other leadership question: does this person have the spiritual maturity, the biblical knowledge, the character to lead; are they walking in alignment with Christ; are they calling others to follow Jesus and grow in faith? A transgender person could, in theory, answer yes to all of these—could be spiritually mature, biblically faithful, calling people toward Christ. But there is something else at stake.

Leadership in the church is about representing Christ and calling people to follow Him; it is about modeling Christ-likeness. When someone leads, people are watching them, learning from them, following their example. So if someone is in transition, or has transitioned, or is living in a gender identity that differs from their biological sex, are they best positioned to call people toward the biblical understanding of the body, gender, and identity? Different churches answer this differently.

What I think is that this requires honest conversation about what your church actually teaches and whether you are willing to live with the tension. If your church teaches that sexual difference is real and created by God, and that the gospel calls people to accept their biological sex and find peace there, then having a leader whose life represents something different creates confusion—it suggests either the teaching is wrong or the leader is not fully submitted to it. But if your church is thoughtful about this, and the leader has thought carefully about it, it is possible to hold both things at once: this is what we teach about the body; this is this particular person's road with that teaching; they are a faithful follower of Jesus; and we can all grow together. The key is honesty. Do not pretend you are not teaching something you are; do not pretend the person in leadership has some other relationship to that teaching than they actually do; let people see the actual complexity and make their own decisions.

FOUR CHURCH MODELS: AFFIRMING, EXCLUSIONARY, WELCOMING-BUT- CAUTIOUS, HONEST

It helps to lay out the approaches different churches actually take. The first is the affirming church. Some

The second is the exclusionary church, which takes the opposite approach. Transgender people are not fully welcome; they can attend, but membership, baptism, and leadership are closed to them, on the logic that the church believes strongly in biblical teaching about gender and cannot have people in visible roles living in contradiction to it. This model is also clear, but it is painful for transgender people who genuinely want to follow Christ, because it says you cannot fully belong here until you stop being transgender. That may be what your church believes—but you should be honest about it.

The third is the welcoming but cautious church. We welcome you as a person; you can attend, you can be baptized if you have come to faith, you can be a member—but we need to be careful about leadership, because leadership is about modeling and calling people toward Christ, and we teach that the gospel calls people to accept their biological bodies, so let us talk about what that means for visible roles. This model says you belong, you are not excluded, but we are also going to think carefully about what leadership looks like given what we actually teach.

The fourth is the church that is honest about

My own conviction sits closest to that last posture. A transgender person who comes to genuine faith in Christ should be baptized, should be welcomed into membership, should be part of the church. But the church should also be honest about what it teaches regarding the body and gender, and it should not pretend that affirming transgender identity is neutral—it is a theological choice; if you make it, own it; if you do not make it, be honest about that too. Leadership requires thinking carefully, not because transgender people cannot be faithful, but because leadership is about representation and influence, and you have to be honest about what your leadership is representing to the people watching. The goal is not exclusion. The goal is honesty—letting transgender people know what they are signing up for, letting your church know what you are teaching, letting the community be united around something real rather than pretending the complexity does not exist.

What does that look like in the room? First, someone who is transitioning or has transitioned comes to your church. Second, you welcome them, and you mean it; you do not make them feel like a sociology experiment. Third, you have a conversation—not an interrogation, a

Underneath all four models, one conviction has to hold: the gospel is the answer, not ideology on either side. Not the ideology that says affirm their transgender identity and everything will be fine—that is false; it promises what it cannot deliver. And not the ideology that says just accept your biological sex and your dysphoria will disappear—that is also false; it promises what it cannot deliver. The gospel says: you are made in God's image; you will have a resurrection body; you matter more than your suffering; your identity is rooted in Christ; let me help you find your way to peace—the real kind, not ideology-driven, but the kind that comes from being reconciled to God and to your own embodied existence. That is the message. That is what the church offers. If your church can offer that, with

BAPTISM, COMMUNION, AND MEMBERSHIP COVENANT

The question of belonging reaches all the way down into the most central acts of the church: baptism, communion, and the membership covenant. These are not marginal rituals; they are the acts that constitute what it means to be the church. If a young person experiencing gender dysphoria cannot participate in them, they cannot fully belong—and if they can participate but only by hiding who they are, that participation is corrupted.

Consider a young person who has experienced gender dysphoria, who has worked with their family and church community, and who decides to be baptized. They are making a covenant with Christ and with the church, saying: I believe in Jesus, I want to follow Him, I want to be part of His people. Should the church baptize them? The answer is almost certainly yes. Baptism is not a reward for theological correctness, not a seal for people who have all the answers; it is a sign that you are claimed by Christ, that your sins are forgiven, that you belong to His people. It is an act of grace that precedes understanding.

There is a real theological complexity here. If you believe that accepting one's biological sex is part of accepting God's creation, does baptizing someone who is rejecting their biological sex contradict your theology? Possibly. But baptism is also an act of grace that operates independently of the candidate's current understanding; the candidate does not have to have perfect theology to be

Communion presents similar questions. A person who is part of your church community, actively following Christ, working toward peace in their embodied existence—do they belong at the Table? Yes. Communion is not a reward for having your theology figured out, nor for agreeing with the church's theology on gender; it is the meal of the reconciled, where we remember Christ's broken body and shed blood. If anything, the person struggling with embodiment needs the symbolic power of communion more, not less—to eat the body and drink the blood, to participate in the mystery that the body matters, that physical reality carries spiritual significance, to be reminded that in the end transformation comes not through escape from embodiment but through resurrection of the body. A person who rejects their body

The membership covenant is where the ongoing relationship gets formalized and expectations get stated. A young person who has experienced dysphoria, who has worked with their family and church, who is following Christ—do they sign a covenant? Yes, but the covenant is worth being explicit about. It might include something like this: as members of this church we believe we are made in God's image; we believe bodies are created good by God; we believe we are called to accept and integrate our embodied existence, that this acceptance is not the same as agreement about contemporary gender ideology, that transformation comes through grace and not ideology, and that all kinds of people—including people with complex experiences around gender and identity—can follow Jesus and belong to His people. We commit to walking with you through genuine discernment. We will not pretend to have all the answers. We will help you think carefully about what you are experiencing. We believe your struggle is real, and we believe your belonging is not conditional on having it all figured out. This is costly belonging. It does not pretend to have all the answers, it does not sidestep the theological questions, but it says clearly: you are ours, we are yours, we will figure this out together.

Most churches have not developed these conversations, and the result is that young people in dysphoria feel that membership requires either complete affirmation of their gender identity or complete rejection of themselves. There is a third way: belonging that holds conviction and

A young person experiencing gender dysphoria might not have it figured out yet, but they can be willing to follow Jesus, willing to be part of the community; they can come to the waters of baptism and be baptized into Christ, and through that act they belong—fully, not conditionally. This changes what is possible. A person who belongs fully can be in conversation with the church about hard questions; a person welcomed to the Table can be transformed slowly by the symbolic power of eating and drinking the body and blood of Christ; a person who is a member of the covenant community has a place from which to ask questions. But if you make belonging conditional—on affirming gender ideology, or on being certain about embodiment, or on agreeing with your interpretation of Scripture—then you cut off the very people who most need the church's help. The church at its best is the place where the most broken people find the most generous welcome; not a welcome that requires them to hide, but a welcome that makes no final demands except this: follow Jesus. That is what baptism, communion, and the membership covenant offer—a way in, a place to belong, a community that will walk

CATHOLIC, ANGLICAN, BAPTIST, PRESBYTERIAN APPROACHES

Different Christian traditions approach transgender people differently, and understanding these approaches is helpful—not because one is obviously right, but because each tradition has something to offer and each has its blind spots. The Catholic approach has historically emphasized natural law theology: the body is created by God, sexual difference is part of His design, and the church's teaching is that transition is not consistent with accepting the goodness of creation. Yet the Catholic tradition also insists that all people are made in God's image and deserve dignity, so you have an official teaching that is restrictive alongside pastoral voices calling for compassion and seeing the person first. Its strength is clear theological grounding that is not negotiable while still trying to hold clarity with compassion; its weakness is that for a transgender person who has made different choices, there is not much room for inclusion in leadership or full belonging—the theology holds, but the practice can feel exclusionary.

The Anglican approach is more diverse, depending on the diocese and the priest. Some Anglican churches fully affirm transgender identity; others take a more traditional view. The Anglican strength is a tolerance for theological difference; the weakness is that this tolerance can look like the church does not actually believe anything. The Baptist approach has traditionally emphasized local church autonomy, so Baptist churches vary widely—some very

Each tradition has lessons. From Catholicism: theology needs to be grounded, not just feelings-based, and the church should teach what it actually believes rather than pretend to be neutral. From Anglicanism: the church should be able to hold some theological diversity without claiming that all positions are equally true. From the Baptist tradition: local communities should have some freedom to work out what they believe in their particular context, not be controlled by a distant bureaucracy. From Presbyterianism: the church should do careful, scholarly thinking about hard questions rather than resort to ideology or feelings. If a church could learn from all of these traditions, it would teach clear theology, honor scholarship, allow for some local variation, and hold conviction with humility.

That is not what most churches look like. Most default to one of two positions—complete exclusion or complete affirmation. Both claim to be based on tradition. Both are actually failures to learn from what the traditions truly offer. The way forward is not ideology. It is belonging held together with honesty.

CHAPTER 11

WHAT TO SAY WHEN SOMEONE YOU LOVE SAYS THEY'RE TRANSGENDER

*A guide for families and friends – what to say,
what not to say, and how to keep loving across
disagreement*

The phone call or the conversation comes. Someone you love—a child, a sibling, a friend, a nephew—tells you they are transgender, and your first feeling is probably some version of this: I do not know what to say, I do not know if I understand this, I do not know if I agree with this, and I do not know how to respond in a way that honors both my love for this person and what I believe to be true. That feeling is honest. It is also paralyzing, because whatever you say in the next few minutes will matter; it

Presence is the first word.

This chapter is for that moment—not to hand you easy answers, but to give you a way of thinking about what to say, what not to say, and how to handle what comes after the door has been opened.

WHAT NOT TO SAY

Begin with what you should not do, because some of the most natural responses are the most damaging. Do not say, "You are confused, you will grow out of this, this is a phase." That dismisses what the person has just trusted you with. You do not know whether it is a phase; it may be, it may not be; but to claim it instantly is to announce that you have already decided what this is and will not listen.

Do not say, "I need to pray about this," and then disappear into prayer while the distance between you quietly widens. Prayer is good, but prayer cannot replace presence. The person in front of you needs to know you are still there—not praying them away from their identity, but praying that you will understand, that the relationship will survive, that you will both find wisdom.

Do not say, "This is a sin, you need to repent." You may believe that gender transition is wrong; you may believe that living outside your biological sex is sin; but the first conversation, when someone is vulnerable enough to tell

Do not say, "You look fine the way you are." They did not ask for your aesthetic opinion; they asked you to hear them, to acknowledge something real about their experience, and "you look fine" misses that this was never about how they look but about how they experience themselves. Do not say, "Are you sure? Maybe you should wait longer before deciding," because they have almost certainly thought about this longer than you know, often for years before saying a word, and questioning their certainty only adds pressure and signals that you do not trust their self-knowledge.

Do not say, "What about the Bible?" The Bible will come up, but not in the first conversation, not as a weapon, not as a way to shut them down; the gospel matters, yet it is not the first word. Do not say, "I support you no matter what, but I am very uncomfortable with this," which sounds supportive but contradicts itself—you are either uncomfortable and wanting to change the situation, or you are supportive; pick one, and if you mean to support them, do not lead with your discomfort, while if you are genuinely uncomfortable, save that for a later and different conversation. And do not say, "I understand, I have always wondered about my gender too," because even if that is true, this is their moment, not yours, and turning it toward your own questions centers you when you should be centering them.

So what should you actually say? Start here: "Thank you for telling me. I know that took courage." Not agreement with their choices, not disagreement—just acknowledgment that they trusted you with something real, and that this matters.

Then: "I love you. That does not change." Say it, mean it, let them hear it, because this is the foundation everything else is built on; if they do not know that your love is not conditional on whether you understand or agree, they will not be able to hear anything else you say. Then open a real conversation: "I want to understand. Tell me what you have been experiencing." Ask what it feels like to experience their gender differently from their biological sex, when this began, what made them decide to tell you—and then listen more than you talk. Your job is not to defend your position. Your job is to understand their experience.

Then be honest about your own ground: "I have some beliefs about the body and gender that are important to me, but I want to work through this together." You are not pretending you have no convictions, and you are not raising those convictions as a weapon; you are saying that you believe certain things, and you love them, and you intend to hold both at once.

WHAT COMES NEXT

So the first conversation is over. What comes next? First, do not rush to decide what you will or will not accept—you do not need to settle pronouns in that moment, you do not need to settle social or medical transition, you do

Second, educate yourself—not from internet rabbit holes but from actual resources. Read what medical professionals say about gender dysphoria, read theology about the body, read testimonies from transgender people, read about detransition; get real information. Third, find people to talk to: a pastor you trust, a counselor, others who have walked through this with their own family members. You need support and a place to process your own feelings, because you should not burden the person who just came out with managing your reaction to their coming out.

Fourth, get help for your loved one—not conversion therapy, not ideology-driven affirmation, but actual psychological care: a therapist who will help them understand what they are experiencing rather than someone who will instantly affirm medical transition or instantly condemn their identity. Just someone who will help them think. Fifth, maintain the relationship. You may not understand, you may not agree, you may need conversations in which you say what you believe—but do not disappear, do not punish them with silence, stay in the relationship.

WHEN THEY MAKE CHOICES YOU THINK ARE HARMFUL

Eventually your loved one may make choices you believe are harmful. They may want to medically

Third, do not make their choices about you. Do not say, "If you transition, I cannot accept that," which turns it into your feelings; say instead, "I think this decision is serious and I want to make sure you have thought it through carefully. How can I help you think?" Fourth, offer your perspective if asked—you believe certain things about the body, you believe the gospel offers a different path, and if they ask, you can share, but it is not your job to convince them, only to love them. Fifth, hold the line on your actual boundaries. There may be things you cannot do; you might not be able to call your child by a new name; you might not be able to support medical transition; you can be honest about that, but be honest gently—not as punishment, as boundary.

And what if you genuinely believe the choices your loved one is making are harming them? This is where it gets hard, because you do not want to be judgmental, yet you also do not want to be a cheerleader for choices you believe are dangerous. Here is what you do: you speak the truth in love. You say, "I love you, and I also believe this choice may not be good for you, for these reasons. Can we

So you ask: "Are you working with a therapist on this? Have you talked to a doctor? Have you thought about the reversible and irreversible aspects? Can you help me understand what you have considered?" If they are deciding without professional support, without having thought it through, under pressure from a community pushing them toward particular conclusions, then you have something to say—not judgment, but honest concern: "I am worried that you are being pushed toward this by an ideology that promises certainty I am not sure exists. I want you to have professional support as you think through this—not a therapist who will affirm whatever you decide, but a real therapist who will help you understand what is happening." This is not rejection. This is love that has teeth.

HOW TO HOLD CONVICTION AND RELATIONSHIP

This is the harder work. How do you maintain a relationship with someone whose choices you believe are wrong? You do it the way Christians have always done it: by separating the person from the choice. Jesus did this. He was critical of people's choices—the rich young ruler, the money changers in the temple, those who wanted to stone the woman caught in adultery—but He did it while holding

Neither do I condemn you. Go and sin no more.

— JOHN 8:11

Both spoken to the same person—no condemnation, and clarity about what righteousness looks like. You can do something similar. You can say to your loved one: "I love you. You are made in God's image. I believe some things about the body and gender that I think matter. I also think some of the choices you are considering may not be best for you. And I am going to stay in this relationship. I am going to listen. I am going to share what I believe when appropriate. I am going to pray for you. And I am going to be here."

This is not easy, and it is also the only thing that actually works. Control does not work. Judgment does not work. Unconditional affirmation of every choice does not work. What works is love that has conviction—relationship that does not require the other person to already agree with you. As you carry this, remember what you owe the person who came out to you. You owe them the truth—not only about gender ideology, but about what Scripture actually teaches, what the gospel actually offers, what peace actually looks like; you do not owe them false agreement, but you owe them honesty. You owe them your presence: you do not have to understand everything, but you do have to show up, maintain the relationship, and refuse to abandon them into ideology on either side.

You owe them time—you do not have to process quickly or lock your position in stone, but you do have to take the time to think, to pray, to learn, to move toward them. You

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN BOUNDARIES AND REJECTION

All of this is true in the first conversations. But how does it work over years rather than minutes? Consider a mother who believes that gender transition is not the path of healing. Her son transitioned three years ago. They still talk regularly, and she still loves him—but the love is not simple. She has learned to use his chosen name and pronouns, which was not difficult once she decided to do it; what is difficult is the ongoing work of holding her actual beliefs alongside her son's choices. When he mentions his hormone therapy, she does not say, "That is good, I am glad you are doing that," and she does not say, "That is sinful and you are ruining your body." She says something like, "I know this is important to you. I still have concerns. But I love you and I want to understand how you are doing."

This is the difference between boundaries and rejection. A boundary says, "This is what I believe, and I

The mistake many families make is thinking they must choose: either "I accept my child's choices," meaning I affirm all of it, or "I maintain my convictions," meaning I withdraw. There is a third way. You maintain your convictions and you maintain the relationship—both. This requires something the church has largely failed to teach: how to disagree with someone without rejecting them, how to believe they are making a wrong choice without making them an enemy, how to hold both concern and love at once. Jesus did this. He had sharp disagreements with people He loved, and He also refused to abandon them. The church needs to recover this capacity.

The family member who comes out as transgender is a permanent disruption to the world you thought was stable. You have spent years understanding that person as one thing—sister, brother, parent, child—and now they are asking you to understand something different; and if you hold deep convictions about what sex and gender mean,

The second thing to know is that you can stay in genuine relationship across this disagreement—not by pretending you have no convictions, not by becoming affirming in your theology to ease the conversation, but by choosing to remain in the room with someone you love even while you believe they have made a choice contrary to Scripture. You can do this. It is hard. It is possible. Practically, you maintain the relationship by not making every conversation about the disagreement; you ask about their life, their work, their relationships—the person in front of you rather than the thing that divides you. You remember their birthday. You show up for their graduation. You do not pretend to celebrate what you believe is harmful, but you celebrate them.

When the conversation does happen—and it will—you speak your convictions clearly and you absorb the anger that comes back. You do not defend yourself by attacking their motives; you do not say "you're just being rebellious" or "you're running from God"; you say what you actually believe Scripture teaches, and you receive their response as someone who has earned the right to respond because

There is a difference between unconditional love and unconditional approval, and the distinction is critical because one is required and the other is impossible. Unconditional love means you do not withdraw your presence because your relative disappoints you; it means you show up even when you believe they have made a choice you think is wrong. Unconditional approval means you pretend to agree when you do not—and that is a lie, and it is not loving; it is abandonment dressed as acceptance. The years will teach you things theology alone cannot. You will watch your relative's pain decrease or increase, their faith deepen or dissolve, their relationships flourish or collapse; you will have access to information that internet arguments never provide; and you may find yourself holding convictions with less certainty than when this began.

This does not mean you change your theology because you love someone. It means you hold your theology with more humility because you have faced the human cost of being wrong about people shaped by your convictions—it means you cannot unsee what you have seen. The hardest part is accepting that you cannot resolve this. You cannot script a neat ending in which your relative returns to traditional sexual ethics or you become affirming. You might get decades of faithful presence alongside an unresolved disagreement, and that might be the only resolution available—and it might be enough. Enough,

The faith required here is larger than the faith required to stay with people who agree with you. It is faith that love is possible across genuine disagreement, faith that the presence of Christ matters more than the agreement of doctrine, faith that years of showing up is a form of evangelism no argument can replicate. Not every family finds this resolution. Some families break. Some choose sides and never reconvene. But some families discover that love is more durable than disagreement—and that showing up year after year in the face of deep conviction holds a power that force never could.

CHAPTER 12

A CHURCH THAT HOLDS THE TRUTH AND WEEPS WITH THOSE WHO WEEP

*The way forward — what a church looks like
when it holds biblical conviction and genuine
compassion together*

The church needs to be the safest place for the most confused person. Not the place where confusion is affirmed uncritically, and not the place where it is mocked, but the place where someone in genuine dysphoria, in genuine questions about their body and their gender, can come and know one thing for certain: I will be heard, I will be loved, I will be helped to think clearly, and I will not be abandoned.

A place that holds the truth and weeps

This has to become the reputation of the church, because it is not the reputation it currently has. Right now, for transgender people, the church is either the place where you get condemned and mocked or the place where you get ideological affirmation without any real relationship; both drive people away, and both fail the person standing in front of you. The church needs to be something else. A place that holds the truth and weeps with those who weep.

WHAT THIS ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE IN THE CHURCH

Let's be concrete about what this means in practice. In the pulpit, the gospel is preached clearly and biblical truth about the body, about sexual difference, about what it means to be made in God's image is taught without apology — but it is taught as good news rather than condemnation, in a way that creates space for people who do not fit the pattern to know they still belong. The sermon does not mock gender-questioning people, and it does not use dysphoria as a cautionary tale; it teaches what Scripture says and lets the weight of that truth stand on its own, because truth does not need mockery to be powerful.

In counseling, the church offers access to good therapists — not affirmative therapists who quickly affirm every gender identity, and not conversion therapists who try to pray away dysphoria, but actual therapists who help people understand what they are experiencing. Is this

In small groups, the church creates space where people can ask questions, where someone dealing with dysphoria can say, "I do not know who I am, I do not know what my gender is, I am confused," and the response is neither "you need to repent" nor "you need to transition" but "tell us more — what are you experiencing, and how can we help you think through this?" In leadership, the church trains its leaders to understand gender dysphoria, to listen without immediately trying to fix, to distinguish between pastoral presence and ideological certainty, and to know that the first job is to understand, not to judge.

In pastoral care, when someone in the congregation is dealing with gender questions — whether they are the person questioning or the parent of someone questioning — the church shows up, offering support, community, and prayer. In hospital visitation, when someone transitions, medically or socially, the church does not disappear; it stays present, not to affirm every choice but to offer Christ's presence. And in education, the church teaches a theology of the body starting with children — what Scripture says about sexual difference, about embodiment, about identity in Christ — not in an abstract way but in a way that helps young people think about themselves as people made in God's image, with bodies that are good, with identities rooted in Christ that go deeper than gender.

THE POSTURE: TRUTH AND LOVE

This is the core move: truth and love simultaneously. Not truth that is loveless, but truth stated in a way that assumes the person in front of you matters. Not love that abandons truth, but love that is willing to say hard things — said to the person's face rather than behind their back, and said because you care about their good.

What does this actually sound like? You meet with someone struggling with dysphoria, and you say: I love you, and you are made in God's image, and that does not change based on how you feel about your gender or what choices you make. I also believe some things about the body — that it is good, that sexual difference is created by God and called good, that the gospel invites us to accept and find peace in our actual embodied existence rather than to escape from the body. I do not know exactly what you are experiencing; I know you are suffering, and I believe the answer to your suffering is not to escape your body but to find your way to peace with your actual embodied existence.

I also do not know whether this will come through acceptance of your biological sex or through some other path. What I know is that you need help thinking through this — actual professional help, not ideology from either side. And I want you to know that no matter what path you take, you belong to God, you are part of His people, and the church is a place where you can explore, ask questions, and work toward understanding who you are. This is truth. And it is love. Not one at the expense of the other.

WHAT THE CHURCH SHOULD NOT DO

The church should not make people choose between their faith and their confusion, should not say, "You have to figure out your gender before you can be part of us," and should not abandon people into the ideology that will promise the certainty the church cannot deliver — it should stay in the relationship. The church should not treat dysphoria as a matter of insufficient faith; dysphoria is not a spiritual problem that prayer alone will solve, though prayer is good, but a psychological and spiritual reality that requires actual care. The church should not pretend medical transition is neutral or inevitable, but should help people think carefully about the costs and consequences. And the church should never use transgender people as a way to prove a theological point or win a culture-war argument.

SPECIFIC PRACTICES FOR PASTORAL CARE

Here are some concrete things a church can do. It can create a resource library — books, articles, and videos from multiple perspectives on gender dysphoria, transgender experience, and biblical theology — so that people can read and learn rather than receive a single ideological line. It can offer support groups for people

It can train leaders on trauma, since many people with dysphoria have experienced trauma and many trans people have experienced rejection and harm, and the church needs to understand both and respond with wisdom. It can create mentorship, pairing people who are struggling with people who have walked similar paths and found faith and peace — not to convert them to a position but to show them what is possible. It can teach in youth group what Scripture actually says about the body, about gender, about identity in Christ, clearly enough that young people have theology to hold onto when they are confused. And it can have good exit conversations: when someone decides to transition, to identify differently, or to make a major choice about their gender, the church does not let them leave silently but tells them, "We love you, we still believe what we believe, but you belong, and the door is open if you want to come back."

BUILDING THE INFRASTRUCTURE: LIBRARY, COUNSELING, SUPPORT, TRAINING

The chapter describes what a church holding truth and love looks like, but the harder question is how a church actually builds the infrastructure to make it possible. First, a library — not just books about gender identity but books from different perspectives: on gender dysphoria from a Christian perspective, on the history of intersex conditions, on the theology of the body, on detransition, on

Third, a support group — not necessarily an official church group, but a context where parents of transgender children can gather, where people who are dysphoric can gather, where people who transitioned and regret it can gather, where people processing questions can gather. These groups do not exist in most churches because churches have largely failed to acknowledge that these communities exist. Fourth, training for leaders: pastoral-care training specifically about gender dysphoria — how to listen, how to distinguish between pastoral presence and taking an ideological side, how to ask good questions without pushing.

Fifth, a clear statement of belief. What does the church actually teach about the body, about sexual difference, about transgender identity? That statement should be clear, and it should be held with humility, but it should be clear; ambiguity is cruel, because it suggests to people that the church does not actually believe what it says. Sixth, clear policies about inclusion and boundaries. A transgender person can be baptized if they have come to faith and can be a member; leadership is something the church thinks carefully about, and different churches will reach different conclusions — but these decisions should be made thoughtfully and clearly, not avoided.

Seventh, ongoing education for the congregation — not

THE COST OF THIS WAY

I want to be honest: doing this right is harder than either dismissal or uncritical affirmation. It requires patience, long-term commitment to people, and the willingness to stay in the hard conversations instead of ending them quickly. It requires you to hold conviction while remaining willing to learn — to be humble about what you do not know while being clear about what you do know.

And it requires you to refuse both camps, the right-wing exclusionists and the left-wing ideologues, and to say, "We are not going to mock, and we are not going to pretend ideology is gospel." That is a harder position to hold. But it is the position worth holding.

THE GOSPEL IS BIG ENOUGH

At the root of all this is a single conviction: the gospel is

What the church needs to believe — and demonstrate through its practices — is that the gospel itself is the answer. Not ideology from the right or the left, but the gospel, and Christ, and the gospel's insistence that you are made in God's image, that your body is good, that your identity is rooted in something deeper than gender, that transformation is possible, and that belonging is not conditional. If the church can offer that, with clarity and love and patience and persistence, then it has something to say to transgender people that the culture cannot say. Then the church is the safest place for the most confused person.

Picture what this could look like. A young person, assigned female at birth, is struggling with their body; they do not know who they are, they are experiencing dysphoria, they are confused. They come to church, and they find a community where people listen and ask questions and do not assume they already understand. Where leaders have real expertise, helping the person think and connecting them with a good therapist without pushing them either toward transition or away from it. Where theology is taught — what Scripture says about the body, about sexual difference, about identity in Christ — not as condemnation but as the foundation for understanding who they are.

WHAT THE CHURCH COULD BE — A VISION OF BELONGING

The church at its best is the place where the most broken people find the most generous welcome — not a welcome that requires them to hide who they are, but one that says: you are made in God's image, your suffering is real, your confusion is understandable, your questions are worth asking, and your belonging is not conditional on having all the answers. Imagine a young person experiencing gender dysphoria walking into your church. They are scared. They have been rejected by family, or at least made to feel conditional. They have been affirmed by internet communities yet know those affirmations are not grounded in real relationship. They have been told by one side that they are sinful and by another that they are simply discovering their true self, told that if they do not

What should they encounter when they walk through the doors? First, people who are not afraid of them — not adults rushing to affirm or condemn based on ideology, but adults genuinely interested in understanding, who know how to ask real questions: Tell me about this. When did you first notice it? What does dysphoria feel like for you? What are you hoping will happen? What are you afraid of? What do you believe about your own experience? Second, clarity about what the church believes about bodies — not in a way that seems dismissive of their suffering, but clearly: that bodies are created good by God, that accepting embodied existence rather than escaping it is the path to peace, that transformation comes through grace rather than ideology on either side, and that many different kinds of people, with many different kinds of embodied experiences, can all follow Jesus, because Scripture teaches it, theology teaches it, and experience teaches it.

Third, patience — not the patience of indefinite limbo, but the patience of someone willing to walk with them through genuine discernment, not pushing toward any particular outcome, just being present, asking questions, offering information, inviting them into community: "We do not have all the answers, but we are going to figure this out together." Fourth, other people — those who have experienced confusion about identity, who have made different choices, who are further along in some kind of process — who can offer perspective without judgment,

Fifth, a pastor or leader who can help them think theologically — not someone performing spirituality or managing emotions, but someone who can say: "Here is what Scripture teaches about bodies, here is what our tradition teaches about accepting embodied existence, and here is how that applies to what you are experiencing. You may come to different conclusions than I have, but we are thinking together, and I believe the gospel offers something different from what the culture offers — it offers actual peace, not escape." None of this is easy. It requires churches to do work they have largely avoided, real theological clarity, staff training, and the willingness to disappoint people on both sides, those who demand complete affirmation and those who demand complete rejection. It requires courage. But it is possible, and it is what faithful pastoral care looks like.

At First Baptist Church of Fenton, this is beginning. We have young people who experience gender dysphoria, families confused about what to do, leaders learning to think carefully about these questions, and people who disagree on significant theological points yet remain committed to loving one another across disagreement. We are learning to ask good questions and to listen carefully to the answers. We use chosen names. We do not rush toward ideology. We help families slow down and think carefully. We make space for questioning without forcing answers, because we believe the gospel is bigger than this

This is not the vision of the progressive church that has abandoned conviction, and it is not the vision of the conservative church that has abandoned compassion. It is the vision of a church that actually follows Jesus — that names the truth, holds conviction, welcomes people, and helps them belong even while they are still figuring out what they believe. This is what the church could be. Not in theory but in practice, in the actual living room where a confused person meets actual Christians who actually know Jesus, where the gospel is not a weapon to prove someone wrong but an invitation to belong to something bigger than the pain. The future of the church on this issue depends on whether it can learn to do this — not a church of ideology, left or right, but a church of wisdom, a church of belonging, a church that loves people more than it loves being right. That is the church worth being part of. That is the church the world needs to see.

So what does it look like when this actually happens, when a young person walks into a church and encounters real pastoral care? They encounter adults who ask genuine questions and listen to the answers, adults not rushing toward an agenda, adults willing to say, "I do not know how to fix this, but I know how to be in relationship with you while you figure it out." They encounter clarity rather than harshness or dismissal — a pastor who can say, "Here is what we believe about bodies, here is what Scripture

And they encounter the gospel — not the gospel as ideology, but the gospel as the message that you are made in God's image, that you are loved without condition, that transformation is possible through encountering Jesus rather than through what the culture offers, that belonging is not earned, and that peace is available even when the path is unclear. This is what the church could be, and it is what the world desperately needs the church to be. Young people in genuine pain need to know there is a place where they can be themselves without hiding, where they can ask real questions, where they can encounter genuine faith rather than performed spirituality, where they can find Jesus before they find answers. That is the church. Not the church of ideology. The church of the gospel.

WHAT IT TAKES

For this to happen, the church has to repent of the harm it has done — the mockery, the abandonment, the refusal to see people. It has to learn what it has refused to learn, about dysphoria, about transgender experience, about the complexity of human existence. It has to teach its theology clearly and lovingly, without apology for what Scripture says but also without cruelty toward people in genuine confusion. It has to show up for people with

If the church does this work, it becomes what it is supposed to be: a place of refuge, a place of truth, a place of love, a place where the most confused person can come and find their way home. That is the way forward.

CONCLUSION

IMAGE-BEARERS FIRST

*Why the gospel refuses to reduce anyone to a
debate — and sees the image-bearer before the
position*

There is a line in Genesis that settles something before any other question arises, a sentence that does its work before the categories of male and female are even explained.

*So God created mankind in his own image, in the
image of God he created them; male and female he
created them.*

— GENESIS 1:27

Before the categories of male and female are explained, they are placed inside a larger truth: image-bearers. That is the foundation, and that is what does not move. Every person you know who is struggling with gender; every person questioning their identity; every person in dysphoria, in confusion, in pain about their body; every person you are tempted to reduce to a position in a culture

*Christ does not reduce people to
positions in a debate.*

THE GOSPEL CANNOT BE HELD HOSTAGE

The church has allowed the gospel to be held hostage by ideology on both sides. The right has used the gospel to justify mockery — to turn transgender people into evidence of cultural decline, to use them as punchlines in sermons and in private conversations, until the gospel became a club with which to beat people in confusion. The left has used the gospel to justify uncritical affirmation — to pretend that every desire a person articulates is a truth that must be affirmed, to treat ideology as gospel, to make belonging conditional on agreement with a particular understanding of gender. Both have taken the gospel and chained it to something it should never be chained to.

The gospel does not belong to the right. The gospel does not belong to the left. The gospel belongs to Christ, and Christ does not reduce people to positions in a debate. What the gospel does is name the person, see the person, and insist that the person is more than any ideology can

WHAT WE KNOW AND WHAT WE DO NOT KNOW

It helps to lay out plainly what the church knows and what it does not. We know that sexual difference is real; it was created by God, male and female is how God made humanity, and Genesis 1:27 is not culturally conditioned but God's design for the human race. We know the body matters and is good — God took a body, God will raise a body, and embodied existence is not a condition we escape but the mode of existence we are created for and resurrected for. We know that image-bearing is what gives human worth, not sexual function or gender identity or reproductive capacity, and that both male and female bear it equally. And we know that identity in Christ runs deeper than any other identity; your politics do not define you, your gender does not define you, your sexuality does not define you — who you are in Christ is what is ultimate.

There is also much we do not know. We do not know exactly what causes gender dysphoria; biology, psychology, social factors, and trauma may all play a role, and we do not have a complete picture. We do not know what the long-term outcomes are for all the medical interventions used to treat it — on some we have data, on others we are still gathering it. We do not know how to help every person in dysphoria find peace, because what works for some may not work for others, and there may be multiple valid paths toward healing. We do not know how to handle every edge case, every variation of human experience, every person who does not fit neatly into categories. What we should do with all of this is hold our

THE GOSPEL RESPONSE TO GENDER CONFUSION

Here is what the gospel offers to someone in gender confusion. Not the ideology that says, "Your internal sense of identity is absolute reality and your body is secondary" — that is Gnosticism wearing modern clothes. Not the cruelty that says, "Your confusion is ridiculous and you need to stop" — that is the failure of compassion. The gospel says something harder than either.

You are made in God's image, and that is your foundation — not your body, not your identity as you experience it, but the simple fact of bearing God's image, which gives you worth that is permanent and not dependent on fitting any category or understanding yourself in any particular way. Your body is good; God created it and God will resurrect it, so your body is not a costume to be exchanged and not incidental but the place where your life happens, and the gospel invites you toward peace with your actual embodied existence rather than escape from it. Your identity is rooted in Christ — not in your gender, not in your sexuality, not in what you feel about yourself on any given day, but in the fact that Christ claims you, loves you, and is forming you into His likeness.

Transformation is possible — not the kind that makes you someone other than who you are, but the kind that helps you be at peace with who you are, that helps you find freedom in your actual existence rather than constant

THE SCANDAL OF THE GOSPEL

The gospel is scandalous in a different way than the culture wars assume. The scandal is not that the church is too strict about gender, nor that it is too affirming about identity; the scandal of the gospel is that it insists you are more than what you think you are. It says that you are trying to find your identity in gender, in sexuality, in political position, in personal preference — and while those things are part of your life, your identity goes deeper, rooted in being made in God's image and being claimed by Christ. That is offensive to every ideology, right and left, because it decentralizes the self: it says you are not the ultimate meaning-maker about your own existence. God is. That is harder than either ideology. It is also more liberating.

THE ESCHATOLOGICAL QUESTION: WHAT WILL BODIES LOOK LIKE?

The gospel's promise of resurrection presses on this question, because someone dealing with dysphoria right now wants to know what that promise means for the body they live in today. The resurrection is not escape from the body but the transformation of it.



— 1 JOHN 3:2

We will be like Christ, and Christ is embodied — He has a body in resurrection. Yet the resurrection body is also transformed.

It is sown a perishable body; it is raised an imperishable body.

— 1 CORINTHIANS 15:42

The body is the same body, but transformed — not destroyed, not replaced, transformed. What does this mean for gender? Here is what we know: in the resurrection we will not need to procreate, and the biological function of sexual difference will not be necessary, so it is possible that gender as we understand it, inextricably tied to reproductive capacity, might be different in resurrection. Here is what we do not know: whether gender will disappear entirely, persist in a different form, or be revealed to be something other than we understood. The resurrection remains mysterious.

But here is what matters. The promise of resurrection means your struggle with your body now is not the final word; your dysphoria now is not eternal; your confusion about your gender now is not the ultimate reality. For someone in dysphoria, that is either hopeful or terrifying depending on what they believe about their gender. If someone believes their true gender is different from their biological sex, the promise that bodies will be transformed could mean, "Maybe in the resurrection my body will finally match who I am." If someone believes that

THE MERCY IN BOUNDARIES: WHEN NO IS AN ACT OF LOVE

Conviction and love belong together, but conviction sometimes has to say no — and the church has to be able to say no without that no becoming cruelty. Consider a parent who believes their adolescent child is moving toward transition too quickly, without adequate psychological evaluation, and who says, "I love you. I will not support medical transition right now. I think you need more time and more professional help to understand what you are experiencing." That is a no. The child hears it as rejection, and the culture around the child names it as rejection: "Your parent does not affirm you. That is violence. That is abuse." But is it?

What the parent is actually saying is, "I love you too much to affirm a medical decision I think is happening too quickly; I think you need to slow down and think carefully,

But if you set a boundary — clearly, lovingly, with full knowledge that it might cost you the relationship — that is love. The parent who says, "I will not affirm medical transition without adequate evaluation," is setting a boundary out of love; the parent might be wrong or might be right, but the boundary itself is not unloving. It is the expression of love that has conviction. The church needs to recover the understanding that no, said with love, is merciful and not cruel. This is one of the hardest things the church has to learn, because in a culture that has redefined all boundaries as oppressive, the church has to insist that there are boundaries that are loving.

THE MONSTER IS NEVER IN THE MIRROR

The book within this book, "The Monster in the Mirror," makes one central claim: the monster is never in the mirror. The slaveholder was not a cartoon monster; he was convinced of his own virtue, part of a community

The church's job is to refuse to be a community that confirms people in wrongness — to be a place where the lens itself gets examined, where assumptions get questioned, where we ask whether we are reading the Bible through a cultural lens rather than letting the Bible challenge our culture. This is hard, because it is much easier to belong to a community that confirms you, and it takes courage to say, "Maybe I am missing something; maybe my culture has shaped my reading of Scripture in ways I am not seeing; maybe the person I thought was clearly wrong is partly right." The beauty of the gospel is that it offers exactly this. The gospel does not require certainty. The gospel requires repentance — the willingness to turn around, the willingness to see things differently.

Instead, the church has largely become another ideological space: left-leaning churches affirm everything,

WHAT THE CHURCH MUST BECOME

If the church is going to offer something the world cannot, it must become a place where people in confusion are safe — not safe from truth, but safe from mockery, safe from abandonment, safe from being reduced to a position. A place where conviction is held clearly, where Scripture is taught and what the gospel says about the body, about sexual difference, about identity in Christ is not hidden but proclaimed and lived. A place where love is genuine rather than performed, not conditional on agreement, the kind of love that extends to people you disagree with and that sees the person before the position.

It must become a place where growth is expected — not forced, but expected — because the church is a community of people trying to become more like Christ, where transformation into Christ-likeness is the goal rather than conformity to culture or mere comfort. And it must become a place where presence is offered: not solutions that are too quick, not judgments that are too swift, but the patient, persistent presence of people who refuse to leave you.

If you are struggling with dysphoria, with gender questions, with confusion about your body and your identity, this is what I want you to know. You are made in God's image, and that fact does not depend on whether you fit a category, whether you understand yourself, whether you are confused or certain. You are valuable. You matter — not because of what you achieve or how you present or what gender identity you claim, but because you are human, because you are made in God's image. Your suffering is real. Your dysphoria is real. The gospel does not dismiss it, but neither does it let that suffering be the final word about who you are.

There is a path toward peace that does not require you to escape your body or embrace ideology. That path is harder than either of those options; it asks you to surrender, to accept, to find your way to being at peace in your actual existence rather than constantly at war with it. That path is available — the gospel offers it, and the church should offer it. You deserve a community that loves you: not one that affirms every choice you make, but one that sees you as a person and not a problem, that walks with you, prays for you, tells you the truth and also tells you that you belong. Find that community. If your church is not offering it, find another church. Keep looking. That community exists.

TO THE CHURCH

And to the church: this is your moment. You can choose mockery or affirmation, and both will fail people. Or you can choose the harder path — truth told in love, conviction

Choose wisely, because the stakes are souls. Real people. Real confusion. Real suffering. The gospel is bigger than any ideology, bigger than any culture war, bigger than any person's gender identity. The gospel says you are made in God's image, you are loved, you are invited into transformation, you are not alone. That is the message the world needs to hear. From the church.

THE FINAL WORD

We came into this book with a question that had no easy answer: What does the Bible say about transgender identity? About gender dysphoria? About the body? About identity? The Bible does not speak directly to contemporary gender ideology. It does not address transgender people as a category. It does not directly say whether someone should transition or how the church should respond. But it speaks clearly about the body, about sexual difference, about image-bearing, about transformation, resurrection, community, and love. And if the church would simply listen to what Scripture actually says, and let that shape how we think and act, we would know what to do.

We would know how to hold truth and love

That is the way. And that is enough.

